Company Registration Number: 09253218 (United Kingdom)

ACORN MULTI ACADEMY TRUST

(A COMPANY LIMITED BY GUARANTEE)

ANNUAL REPORT AND FINANCIAL STATEMENTS

FOR THE YEAR ENDED 31 AUGUST 2024

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Bishop Fleming

ACORN MULTI ACADEMY TRUST
(A COMPANY LIMITED BY GUARANTEE)

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REFERENCE AND ADMINISTRATIVE DETAILS

Members	Representative for EDEN (Exeter Diocesan Education Network) Representative for SDBE (Diocese of Salisbury Education Trust) Representative for Diocese of Bath & Wells Chair of Directors, Mr B Impey
Trustees	Mr B Impey, Chair Ms A Rice, Chief Executive (Resigned 31 August 2024) Mr P Middlemast Ms L Adams Mrs V Singer (Resigned 14 March 2024) Ms S Miller Mrs J Hodge Mrs C Hales (Appointed 5 September 2023)
Company registered number	09253218
Company name	Acorn Multi Academy Trust
Principal and registered office	The Old Tool Office Chard Street Axminster Devon EX13 5EB
Company secretary	Ms V Dower
Chief executive officer	Ms A Rice
Senior leadership team	Mrs A Rice*, Executive Head and Chief Executive Officer Mr P Beare, Acting Head of Marshwood CE Primary Academy Ms H Wicken, Head of Membury Community Primary (appointed 1st September 2024) Mrs D Butler, Head of St Andrews CE Primary Academy Ms C Pooley, Head of Loders CE Primary Academy Mrs J Evans, Head of Thorncombe, St Marys CE VC Primary School Mrs C Porter*, Chief Financial Officer (resigned 31/08/2024) Mrs S Brett*, Business Operations Manager (resigned 31/08/2024) Mrs C Hulbert, Head of Axminster Primary Academy Miss K Lyons, Head of Mrs Ethelston's CE Primary Academy * Deemed to be key management personnel for the purposes of disclosure in the financial statements
Independent auditors	Bishop Fleming LLP Chartered Accountants Statutory Auditors Salt Quay House 4 North East Quay Sutton Harbour Plymouth PL4 0BN

REFERENCE AND ADMINISTRATIVE DETAILS (CONTINUED)
FOR THE YEAR ENDED 31 AUGUST 2024

Bankers	Lloyds Bank plc 16 The Triangle Avon Cleavedon BS21 6NG
Solicitors	PHP Law LLP 6 Delamore Park Cornwood Ivybridge PL21 9QP

Acorn Multi Academy Trust Trustees' Report for the period 1 September 2023 to 31 August 2024.

The Trustees present their annual report together with the financial statements and auditor's report of the charitable company for the period from 1 September 2023 to 31 August 2024. The annual report serves the purposes of both a Trustees' report, and a Directors' report under company law. The Trust operates a multi academy trust for primary aged pupils serving a catchment area in East Devon and West Dorset. The Trust is made up of 7 primary schools with a combined pupil capacity of 856 pupils and had a roll of 709 plus 39 nursery pupils in the school census in October 2023.

STRUCTURE, GOVERNANCE AND MANAGEMENT

Constitution

The academy trust is a company limited by guarantee and an exempt charity. The charitable company's memorandum and articles of association are the primary governing documents of the academy trust. The Trustees of Acorn Multi Academy Trust Limited are also the directors of the charitable company for the purposes of company law. The charitable company is known as Acorn Multi Academy Trust.

Details of the Trustees who served throughout the year, and to the date the accounts are approved are included in the Reference and Administrative Details.

Members' liability

Each member of the Charitable Company undertakes to contribute to the assets of the Charitable Company in the event of it being wound up while he/she is a member, or within one year after he/she ceases to be a member, such amount as may be required, not exceeding £10 for the debts and liabilities contracted before he/she ceases to be a member.

Trustees' indemnities

The Academy Trust through its Articles has indemnified its Trustees to the fullest extent permissible by law. During the period the Academy Trust also purchased and maintained liability insurance for its Trustees.

Method of Recruitment and Appointment or Election of Trustees

The Acorn Multi Academy Trust Articles of Association state that:

- The number of Directors shall be not less than five (appointed under Articles 50 and 50A), but (unless otherwise determined by ordinary resolution) shall not be subject to any maximum
- The Members shall appoint by ordinary resolution a minimum of two Directors (Article 50).
- Provided that the total number of (Foundation) Directors appointed under Article 50A shall not exceed a simple majority of the total number of Directors:
  i) EDEN shall appoint no fewer than two directors;
  ii) SDBE shall appoint no fewer than one director; and
  iii) in the event that a Church Academy located in a Diocese other than those administered by either EDEN or SDBE joins the Company, the relevant Diocesan Corporate Member shall appoint no fewer than one director.
- Providing that the Chief Executive Officer agrees so to act, the Members may by ordinary resolution appoint the Chief Executive Officer as a Director (Article 57).
- The Directors may appoint Co-opted Directors (Article 58).
- The total number of Directors, including the Chief Executive Officer if they so choose to act as Director under Article 57, who are employees of the Company shall not exceed one third of the total number of Directors (Article 50B).

Term of office

The term of office for any trustee shall be 4 years. When appointing new trustees, the Board will give consideration to the skills and experience mix of existing trustees in order to ensure that the Board has the necessary skills to contribute fully to the academy's development.

Policies and Procedures Adopted for the Induction and Training of Trustees

New Trustees are appointed based on specific skill sets identified by an analysis of the needs of the Trust. The training and induction provided for new Trustees will depend upon their existing experience but would always include a tour of the Academies and a chance to meet staff and pupils. All Trustees are provided with copies of policies, procedures, minutes, accounts, budgets, plans and other documents that they will need to undertake their role as Trustees. Induction tends to be done informally and is tailored specifically to the individual. Training has been provided by Devon Education Services Governance Support Team for all Trustees. Trustees also have access to further general training and support provided by the Exeter Diocesan Board of Education, Diocese of Salisbury Education, as well as the National Governors Association Learning Link and the Devon Association of Governance. Details of all courses and events are circulated to all trustees by the Clerk and Trustees are encouraged to attend. Relevant newsletters, publications and guidance are circulated by the clerk to keep Trustees informed of statutory requirements and changes in legislation.

Organisational structure

The Board of Trustees normally meets once each half term. The Board establishes an overall framework for the governance of the Multi Academy Trust and determines membership, terms of reference and procedures of Committees and other groups. It receives reports including policies from its Committees for ratification. It monitors the activities of the Committees through the minutes of their meetings. The Board may from time to time establish Working Groups to perform specific tasks over a limited timescale.

The Trustees are responsible for setting general policy, adopting an annual plan and budget, approving the statutory accounts, monitoring the Academies by the use of the budgets and other data, and making major decisions about the direction of the Trust, capital expenditure and staff appointments. The Finance and Audit committee meets six times a year and is responsible for monitoring, evaluating and reviewing policy and performance in relation to financial management, compliance with reporting and regulatory requirements and reporting, receiving internal audit reports and drafting the annual budget including setting staffing levels. It also incorporates the role of an audit committee.

Each school also has its own local governing body that monitors the performance of their own school as well as maintaining its unique identity.

The Trustees and Board of Trustees have devolved responsibility for day to day management of the Multi Academy Trust to the CEO and Senior Leadership Team (SLT). The SLT comprises the CEO, Heads of School, the Chief Financial Officer (CFO) and the Business Operations Manager. The SLT implements the policies laid down by the Trustees and reports back to them on performance. The CEO is the Accounting Officer.

Arrangements for setting pay and remuneration of key management personnel

The key management personnel comprise the Board of Trustees, the Chief Executive Officer, the Chief Financial Officer, the Business Operations Manager and the School Improvement Advisor.

All Trustees give their time freely and no Trustee received remuneration in the year in respect of their role as a Trustee.
The pay of employed key management personnel is reviewed annually as part of the appraisal process.

The Chief Executive Officer appraisal is conducted by the CEO appraisal panel. A pay award is decided based upon performance and other factors such as pupil numbers and size of the Multi Academy Trust.

The Chief Financial Officer and Business Operations Manager follow the same appraisal process as support staff within the academy trust.

Headteacher's pay increase is in accordance with the School Teachers' Pay and Conditions Document (STPCD). The Head of School must demonstrate sustained high quality of performance in respect of Academy leadership and management and pupil progress, and is subject to a review of the totality of their performance by the CEO. The pay and performance committee may award one reference point for sustained, high quality performance in line with the Academy's expectations.

Trade union facility time

There are no employees who were relevant union officials during the relevant period.

Related Parties and other Connected Charities and Organisations

The Acorn Multi Academy Trust consists of seven schools from East Devon and West Dorset. The Trust works closely with other schools outside the Trust including The Woodroffe Pyramid. The Trust is working with South Central Teaching School hub and Woodroffe School to provide provision for the Early Career Teacher induction programme. The Acorn Multi Academy Trust works with the universities of Exeter, Bath Spa and St Mark and St John's Plymouth to provide teaching practice placements.

Acorn Multi Academy Trust worked closely with First Federation Trust over the audit period prior to the transfer.

OBJECTIVES AND ACTIVITIES

Objects and Aims

The Trust's object is specifically restricted to the following:

To advance for the public benefit education in the UK, particular but without prejudice to the generality of the foregoing by establishing, maintaining, carrying on, managing and developing academies which shall offer a broad and balanced curriculum, which shall include Church of England academies designated as such, which shall conduct in accordance with the principles, practices and tenets of the Church of England both generally and in particular in relation to arranging for Religious Education and daily acts of worship, and having regard to any advice issued by the Diocesan Board of Education. Other academies whether with or without a designated religious character, but in relation to each of the academies to recognise and support their individual ethos, whether or not designated Church of England.

Objectives, strategies and activities

The key objectives of the Trust are to ensure that every child has the best possible educational experience so that they achieve the best possible outcomes. The strategies for achieving these objectives are defined in the Acorn Trust Strategic plan. We aim to be (Christian) schools (where designated), at the heart of our communities, working together to enable children to grow creatively and to achieve their best in a happy and secure environment.

The priorities for the Trust for the year 2023/24 were:

- To plan and prepare the Trust to merge with a larger Trust during 2024/25.
- To ensure due diligence is carried out on all aspects of both Trusts strategically, financially, educationally, operationally.
- To continue to improve quality of teaching in core subjects to ensure improvements in outcomes.
- To further develop provision for SEMH (Social, Emotional and Mental Health) and SEND (Special Educational Needs and Disabilities) through a range of strategies that impact on classroom practice.

Collaboration to improve outcomes for children

The Trust academies have a shared commitment to formal collaborative working to establish a strong professional partnership where staff can support and stimulate each other in all aspects of teaching and learning and leadership and management. The benefits of this approach are:

- An absolute focus on improving outcomes for children.
- Improved teaching and learning through sharing best practice.
- Enhanced learning and curriculum opportunities for children.
- A coherent system of professional development, support and accountability.

Public benefit

The Academy provides educational services to all children in the local area. The Trustees confirm that they have complied with the duty in Section 17(5) of the Charities Act 2011 to have due regard to the Charity Commissioner's general guidance on public benefit in exercising their powers or duties. They have referred to this guidance when reviewing the Academy's aims and objectives and in planning its future activities.

STRATEGIC REPORT

Acorn Multi Academy Trust was established in 2014 as a group of geographically close schools working on the borders of East Devon and West Dorset. The Trust is a mixed multi academy trust of church and Community schools who work in formal collaboration to improve outcomes for all the children in our Trust. This collaborative working is central to our school improvement strategy as staff and children are able to learn from each other to develop and share best practice.

Our Vision:
To provide high quality education and deliver the best possible outcomes for young people, enabling every child to flourish, regardless of background.

Our Ethos:
We are united by our passion for working collaboratively to achieve the best possible outcomes in all our schools. Each of our academies are separate and distinct and their differences are valued. This character and distinctiveness are protected and developed in each school and are at the heart of their communities. This is within a structure that is supportive and collaborative so that staff and children are not isolated but benefit from opportunities to develop and grow.

The Trust Board has continued to work alongside colleagues from the DfE, the three Diocesan representatives and the Regional Director to ensure the long-term sustainability of the Trust through a transfer to The First Federation Trust. The working party made an application to the Headteacher Board for approval in November 2023 and approval was given in January 2024 with a planned conversion date of 1 September 2024. The joint party met regularly to provide strategic direction for the merger and look at different aspects of the organisation to ensure a smooth transition. This involved discussions with leaders and visits to schools to begin to build a shared understanding of the ethos and culture of each Trust. During the Summer term the TUPE process took place and staff were consulted on potential changes to the proposed organisational structure. Staff from both Trusts worked together to share information and ensure that the transition to the new Trust in September would be smooth and allow the schools to continue to run operationally while continuing to share new systems and operations, but also to continue to develop educational outcomes. The transfer was completed on time and staff were transferred on 1 September 2024 to The First Federation Trust.

The Trust successfully bid for several CIF projects including site security and safeguarding at Axminster. The site at Axminster is surrounded by local housing and this project has allowed the site to be secure across the whole perimeter as well as providing CCTV and an electronic signing in system. This will ensure the children are safe at all times and the site is safe when the site is empty.

Thorncombe was able to benefit from a successful bid to replace the flat roof so it will no longer leak and cause deterioration of the building, as this has been an ongoing problem for several years.

The roof damage at Loders caused by a storm in November 2023 was finally repaired. This damage was caused by a mini tornado in the village and has resulted in a class being taught in the hall for the rest of the year. This will have a significant impact on the effective operation of the school.

The Trust has worked with Salisbury Diocese and Marshwood PCC to develop a plan to allow Marshwood church to continue operating for another year while a permanent solution can be found to enable the Church to continue as a school and community asset. The loss of the Church would have a serious impact on Marshwood school to deliver the full curriculum as it provides space for collective worship, PE, music and wider school activities.

The Trust has worked with Axminster Primary Academy and Devon County council to establish a family hub based at Axminster to provide a wide range of family services and outreach work for families in the area. This will replace the current centre at Seaton and will enable the school to provide effective early help to many more families. It will also provide parenting and a base for a wider range of outside agencies to work with our local families around Axminster. Since the Covid 19 pandemic, the level of need has increased significantly and this will make a significant difference to addressing the local needs of our families, alongside the school and nursery.

The main focus this year has been to improve educational outcomes in the core subjects of reading, writing and maths with a particular emphasis on filling the gaps in maths through developing key fluency facts. This has had some success but still needs time to embed further. There has been professional development across the Trust to improve staff expertise and subject knowledge in maths to ensure children are making progress. The writing curriculum has also been reviewed to ensure children are able to apply their knowledge to their writing independently and have the stamina to write at length.

The inclusion lead has worked across all schools this year to ensure children have the appropriate support that they need and that their needs are being met in the classroom and this enables them to access the curriculum at their level. There has been significant work with outside agencies to continue to address persistent behaviour issues to ensure that these children are not at risk of exclusion or suspension. Schools have used their expertise in relational policy and practice to draw up effective support plans and manage behaviour consistently through an approach that sees behaviour as a form of communication. This has been a successful approach and where exclusions have taken place there has been a clear trail of evidence of strategies that have been applied and there is evidence that the school could do no more to address the issues.

The national agenda to improve attendance following the pandemic has been a key focus to improve outcomes and decrease persistent absence. The MAT has implemented a systematic approach to reporting persistent absence to parents on a termly basis through a series of letters of increasing severity and working with parents to improve attendance where possible. In the recent Ofsted inspections, it has been noted that the schools have been doing all that they can to encourage improved attendance with some excellent case studies of significant impact.

Achievement and Performance

The results below indicate the outcomes for 2024. Small cohorts have an impact on the percentages compared to the National outcomes but can sometimes relate to a single child. Overall, the results show strong performance in EYFS and year one phonics. The Trust has been using Read, Write inc for three years and the effectiveness of the scheme enables schools to continue to achieve well with phonics outcomes to ensure our youngest children are able to read using their phonic knowledge.

In key stage two, the reading results are broadly in line with the national average and continue an upward trend. With the exception of Mrs Ethelston's Primary there is still work to be done to improve outcomes at key stage 2.

School	Number of children in year group	EYFS %	Number of children in year group	Y1 Phonics %	Number of children in year group	Y2 R %	Y2 W %	Y2 M %	Number of children in year group	Y4 Average Attainment Score	Y4 MTC % (25/25)	Number of children in year group	SATs Y6 R % ARE & GDS GDS		Y6 W % ARE & GDS GDS		SATs Y6 M % ARE & GDS GDS	
AX	41	63	31	61	50	63	46	50	35	20.2	36	45	56 Appealing 2 Reading (60%)	16	44	7	47	9 Appealing 1 GDS (11%)
LD	3	66	8	88	11	73	55	73	9	24	56	9	44* Appealing 1 Reading (56%)	11	67	0	56	22
MW	4	75	5	100	4	75	50	50	8	14.25	0	13	92	23	46	8	54	8
MB	1	0	1	100	5	20	0	20	1	17	0	1	100	0	0	0	100	0
UE	31	74	25	88	30	76	80	76	26	19	27	24	91	29	74	40	79	21
CS	18	78	13	100	16	81	81	81	20	21	20	24	75	25	67	13	58 Appealing 3	0
TH	2	50	7	86	2	50	50	50	4	16	0	4	100	0	75	0	25	0

There have been several Ofsted inspections during the academic year 23/24. In October Thorncombe St Marys received its first inspection since joining the Trust in 2019 when it was a sponsor academy. There has been significant turnover of staff during this time including change of leadership, but the impact of the work done by school leaders and the Trust to improve this school was recognised. The report states "astute Trust leaders have brought stability and rigour. This is providing a firm platform for speedy and necessary change". The school achieved a good grading in leadership and management, behaviour and attitudes, personal development and early years provision. The quality of education still requires improvement as pupils are not building their knowledge well enough across the full curriculum. The school also received a letter from Amanda Spielman (HMCI) "It is clear from the report that school and Trust leaders are working in partnership to bring about improvement. I am delighted to read that your team is focussed on developing children's curiosity and readiness to learn. Furthermore, it is good to know that pupils become fluent early readers who now choose to read for pleasure."

Mrs Ethelston's Primary was inspected in February 2024 and achieved a Good grade in every area and outstanding for personal development. Ofsted commented that leaders have high expectations of what children can achieve and have put an ambitious curriculum in place. The school has taken prompt action to address weaknesses evident in its most recently published outcomes. The school was delighted that the report identified that children attend school regularly because they enjoy what they learn and they do every day!"

Membury Primary received an upgraded inspection in May 2024. There were only 13 children on roll and there have been many staff changes in key stage one over the last two years, The report stated that " The trust, school leaders and governors are committed to the school and they have a shared vision. Across the school, they have developed a positive and supportive culture. However, numerous staff changes have had an impact on the quality of education provided and this has hindered the schools drive to improve. The curriculum now needs to be more carefully adapted to meet the needs of all children, particularly those with SEND.

Marshwood Primary Academy was inspected in May 2024. The report acknowledged the good work that had already been achieved by the Trust and senior leaders "trust and school leaders have worked together to understand the school's strengths and areas for development. The trust supports school leadership to improve the school's provision and raise standards". This was reflected in the work in reading and phonics where outcomes were strong. However, "The curriculum is not implemented as the school intends in some subjects" and the school will continue to work on this. The school was proud that pupils were described as " confident and happy. They are polite and considerate to one another. Pupils treat their friends and adults with respect" as this reflects the strong Church school ethos of the school.

St Andrews Primary, Chardstock was inspected in March 2024. The school achieved "good" for early years, behaviour and attitudes, personal development but leadership and management and quality of education remained as "requires improvement". The report recognised that "The trust has supported the school to begin to address some of the weaknesses in provision that are evident in the most recent published outcomes", but felt there was not a well-informed view of the effectiveness of the curriculum and the impact of these changes. As a result, some children have gaps in their understanding and some pupils' needs are not well met. However, pupils are keen to learn, enjoy attending school and pupils and parents value the support and care that school staff provide. The Trust had employed an external consultant to provide additional external validation for the school and this inspection did not reflect the feedback that had been given to staff during the year. The school raised a complaint regarding the first inspection and further evidence was collected by an additional inspector on an additional visit.

Key Performance Indicators

The number of children on roll is a key performance indicator as funding is based on pupil numbers. Across the Trust total pupil numbers are 709 (39 nursery) in the October 2023 census.

Another key performance indicator is payroll costs as a % of total expense. This is currently 81% which is the same as the previous year. The Trust aims to keep salary costs at 80% or below of total expense through sharing staff and expertise and reducing overheads as the Trust grows. This remains a challenge due to statutory obligations such as NI increases, pension contribution increases and increase in the national living wage.

Going Concern

The Board of Trustees have given consideration to the long-term financial sustainability of the trust and have been exploring options for growth in the form of a multi academy trust merger. The trust formed a joint project board with The First Federation Trust in 2023/24, prior to the transfer of the seven schools in the trust to The First Federation Trust on 1 September 2024. As a result, these financial statements have been prepared on a basis other than going concern.

FINANCIAL REVIEW

During the year to 31 August 2024, funding was based on October 2022 pupil numbers of 699. Pupil numbers are currently 709 as per the October 2023 census.

With the exception of one-off grant income, the Trust's core income is received in the form of recurring annual grants from the ESFA. This includes General Annual Grant, Teachers pension and pay grant, Pupil Premium, Recovery Premium, High Needs Funding, Sports Funding, Nursery Grants and Universal Free School Meals funding. Income is also received in the form of donations for trips and specific projects. This funding is spent directly on the education of the pupils within the Trust.

The Trust also receives unrestricted income from other sources such as the sale of meals and paid fees from the nursery. This income may be used by the Trustees to support the educational aims of the Trust and to build up reserves for use as specified in the reserves policy.

The Trust may also apply for conditional improvement grants offered by the Department for Education for the maintenance and improvement of fixed assets. The Trust had 2 new CIF projects and 5 ongoing projects in the year 23/24. The amounts awarded for the new projects were as follows:

- Axminster Primary £287,843 for security and safeguarding
- Thorncombe Primary £262,550 flat roof recovering.

The ongoing projects as follows were all completed within the year. The income for these projects was recognised in previous years:

- Mrs Ethelston's Primary - rebuild the retaining wall
- Axminster Primary- fire compliance
- Marshwood Primary -fire safety and compliance work
- Marshwood Primary - removal of asbestos and roof replacement
- Thorncombe Primary -fire compliance work

Salary payments to teachers and support staff comprise the largest recurring expense of the academies and central support function.

The Trust makes contributions to both the Teachers' Pension (TPS) and Local Government Pension Scheme (LGPS). The TPS is a national scheme managed by the Department for Education. Assets and Liabilities are not allocated to individual employees. In the LGPS however, the assets and liabilities are subject to an actuarial valuation and are attributable to individual employers. The balance sheet contains the net pension deficit in respect of current and prior employees. Although a deficit does not indicate the liability will become payable, it does indicate that the current employer contributions may not meet the liabilities and assets of the scheme in the long term.

During the year and with the assistance of pupil premium and recovery premium grants, the trust has continued to invest in Read Write Inc to improve phonics and reading and Lexia, a language support program that supports individual language difficulties online. Other curriculum packages such as Accelerated Reader and Kapow have continued to be purchased at trust level for all the schools to benefit from.

In summary, for the year ending 31st August 2024, the total incoming resources (unrestricted and restricted general funds excluding Condition Improvement Fund (CIF), Devolved Formula Capital (DFC) and pension reserve) of £5,742,171 for the Trust is less than the total expenditure (unrestricted and restricted general funds excluding CIF, DFC and pension reserve) of £6,223,251 resulting in an in-year deficit of £481,080. The reserves balance carried forward at 31st August 2024 is £244,851 unrestricted and £17,975 restricted general funds (excluding FA and Pension fund). In addition, reserves carried forward include unspent capital funding carried forward (CIF and DFC) of £376,105.

Reserves Policy

At present the level of reserves is reviewed regularly by the Finance and Audit Committee, and recommendations are put forward to the Full Governing Board annually. The trust reviews the opportunities and risks at a trust level in order to assess the required level of resources needed to meet expected and unexpected needs in the short and long term. The current reserve policy requires that a capital reserve be created to fund future capital expenditure and that a revenue reserve be created to fund both operational and strategic aims of the trust.

The capital reserve represents unspent capital projects. The balance brought forward at 31st August is £376,105.

Revenue Reserves are split into strategic and operational.

Operational reserves are intended to be sufficient to allow for the educational facilities and services of the trust to be maintained for the short term (within the current academic year). The minimum level for this reserve is 5% of GAG income. For the academic year 24/25, the minimum level of this reserve is £210,975 and it will provide for increases to salaries, utility costs and absence costs beyond those budgeted.

Strategic reserves consider longer term aspirations of the trust. The free reserves balance of £244,851, all of which is unrestricted funds and will be transferred to The First Federation trust at the end of the financial year.

Due to the nature of funding the Trust has in the 23/24 academic year held significant cash balances for operational and strategic requirements. The Trustees authorised the opening of additional investment accounts to take advantage of higher interest rates.

Investment Policy

Due to the nature of funding the Trust holds significant cash balances surplus to its short-term requirements. The Trustees have authorised the use of a cash savings platform which enables the trust to manage investments and generate better returns. The investment policy specifies the types of investments that are permitted, and this policy is reviewed annually by Trustees.

Trustees regularly review the risks of Acorn Multi Academy Trust and have established a risk management register for the Trust, as well as the internal controls mentioned elsewhere. Where significant financial risk still remains, they have ensured they have adequate insurance cover.

PRINCIPAL RISKS AND UNCERTAINTIES

The Board of Trustees has reviewed the major risks to which the Academy Trust is exposed together with the operating, financial and compliance controls that have been implemented to mitigate those risks.

Financial: The Multi Academy Trust has considerable reliance on continued Government funding through the ESFA. The trust is Government funded and there is no assurance that Government policy or practice will remain the same or that public funding will continue at the same level or on the same terms.

Legal and Regulatory: The risk in this area arises from potential failure to comply with regulations and legislation, follow internal controls or complete statutory returns. An internal audit is carried out annually to carry out checks on financial systems and records as required by the Academies Financial Handbook. The Trustees continue to review practice and policy and ensure that appropriate measures are in place to mitigate these risks.

Estates Management: The risk is identified as potential failure to ensure the trust's estate is safe, well maintained and complies with relevant regulations. The premises manager provides assurance to the Trustees with a robust maintenance schedule detailing statutory obligations. a rolling Health and Safety audit program, good and consistent health and safety policies and risk assessments and staff training. The trust is insured under the RPA for unexpected and unforeseen damage to property.

Reputational - The continuing success of the trust is dependent on continuing to attract sufficient numbers of pupils by providing the highest educational standards. To mitigate this risk, Trustees ensure that pupil outcomes are closely monitored and reviewed.
Safeguarding and child protection - The Trustees continue to ensure that the highest standards are maintained in areas of recruitment and monitoring of staff, the operation of child protection policies and procedures, health and safety and discipline.

Staffing - The success of the Trust is reliant upon the quality of its staff and so the Trustees monitor and review policies and procedures to ensure continued development and training of staff as well as ensuring continued investment and supporting the wellbeing of staff. Recruitment of staff continues to be a challenge at all levels. The number of applicants at teacher and support staff level is low and the quality is also not as good as the trust would like. The retention of support staff is also challenging due to low pay rates, part time hours and term time only contracts. This situation looks likely to get worse in the future.

The Trust has continued to strengthen its risk management process through the year by improving the process and ensuring staff awareness. A risk register is maintained and reviewed and updated on a regular basis.

The Trustees have assessed the major risks to which the Trust is exposed, in particular those relating to financial and economic, strategic and reputational, legal and regulatory, political, environmental and infrastructure and operational. The Trustees have implemented a number of systems to assess and minimise those risks, including internal controls described elsewhere. Where significant financial risks still remain they have ensured adequate insurance cover.

FUNDRAISING

The academy trust does not use any external fundraisers.

PLANS FOR FUTURE PERIODS

The Trust transferred to The First Federation Trust on 1 September 2024.

FUNDS HELD AS CUSTODIAN TRUSTEE ON BEHALF OF OTHERS

None of the Acorn Multi Academy Trust academies hold funds on behalf of others.

AUDITOR

In so far as the Trustees are aware:

- There is no relevant audit information of which the Charitable Company's auditor is unaware; and
- The Trustees have taken all steps that they ought to have taken to make themselves aware of any relevant audit information and to establish that the auditor is aware of that information

Trustees' report, incorporating a strategic report, was approved by order of the board of Trustees, as the company directors, on 17th December 2024 and signed on the board's behalf by:

Mr B Impey
Chair of Trustees

Scope of Responsibility

As Trustees we acknowledge we have overall responsibility for ensuring that Acorn Multi Academy Trust has an effective and appropriate system of control, financial and otherwise. However, such a system is designed to manage rather than eliminate the risk of failure to achieve business objectives and can provide only reasonable and not absolute assurance against material misstatement or loss.

As Trustees, we have reviewed and taken account of the guidance in DfE's Governance Handbook and competency framework for governance.

The Board of Trustees has delegated the day-to-day responsibility to the Executive Headteacher/CEO, as accounting officer, for ensuring financial controls conform with the requirements of both propriety and good financial management and in accordance with the requirements and responsibilities assigned to it in the funding agreement between Acorn Multi Academy Trust and the Secretary of State for Education. They are also responsible for reporting to the Board of Trustees any material weaknesses or breakdowns in internal control.

GOVERNANCE

The information on governance included here supplements that described in the Trustees' Report and in the Statement of Trustees' Responsibilities. The board of Trustees has formally met 9 times during the year.

Attendance during the year at meetings of the board of Trustees was as follows:

Trustee	Meetings Attended	Out of a possible
B Impey (Chair)	9	9
A Rice (CEO and accounting officer)	7	9
P Middlemast	7	9
L Adams	9	9
S Miller	9	9
J Hodge	9	9
C Hales	9	9
V Singer	3	5

The key changes in the composition of the board were as follows:
Mr B Impey was elected Chair of the board of Trustees on 14 September 2023.
Mrs V Singer resigned as a foundation trustee on 14 March 2024.
Mrs A Rice resigned as a trustee on 31 August 2024
Mrs C Hales was appointed as a foundation trustee on 5 September 2023

Governance arrangements at all levels were further strengthened by the following actions:

- Improving communication across all levels of governance was a focus in 2023-24. Half termly meetings of Chairs of Local Governing Bodies (LGBs) with the Chair and CEO continued through 2023-24.
- Delegated powers were reviewed and updated, followed by a revision of the Scheme of Delegation and governance documents in September 2023.
- Governance at local level was strengthened with the recruitment of governors with skills in education and links to the community and in church schools to the local parish.
- Scholarpack, the pupil performance tracking system linking SIMS and performance data has enabled governors and trustees to have a detailed and accurate understanding of pupil progress.
- A Trust SLA with the NGA Learning Link was renewed for 2023/24, giving access to high quality training and development to governors at all levels, alongside face to face and online training with Devon Education Services.
- Appointed Trustees for Safeguarding, SEND and Pupil Premium provided key information to the Trustees to support their oversight. By supporting the Trust both in the Board meetings and outside them, the Board have a comprehensive knowledge of how the Trust is working and are able to identify areas for them to address accordingly.

Governance Reviews:

The Trust has undertaken two activities during the period designed to assess the effectiveness of the board of Trustees and its committees.

The trust board and local governing bodies carried out skills audits in the spring of 2024 to assess the skills, knowledge and experience contained within the Trustees and the local governors. The skills and competencies audit evaluated the Board's expertise, identified gaps in skills or knowledge and proactively sought to provide training for the key areas.

The trust board and local governing bodies undertook self-evaluations in the spring and summer of 2024.

The trust board completed a MAT Board online appraisal. This self-evaluation helped the board identify strengths and key areas for development. An analysis of the appraisal report was followed by the creation of a governance action plan. The development and review of the governance action plan enabled all trust board members to be actively engaged in improving the effectiveness of the governing board over the 2023-24 academic year.

The Finance and Audit Committee is a sub-committee of the main Board of Trustees and meets six times a year.

The Finance & Audit Committee is responsible for;

- monitoring, evaluating and reviewing policy and performance in relation to financial management
- compliance with reporting and regulatory requirements
- reviewing and monitoring reports from the Internal Auditor
- drafting the annual budget including setting staffing levels
- authorising spending within agreed budgets
- performing the role of an audit committee
- receiving and recommending statutory accounts to the trust board
- human resources
- asset management, facilities management & health & safety

The Chief Financial Officer is a member of the Finance & Audit Committee.
During the year, J Hodge joined the committee.
Attendance at meetings in the year was as follows:

Trustee	Meetings attended	Out of a possible
S Miller (Chair)	5	6
B Impey	5	6
A Rice (CEO and Accounting Officer)	6	6
L Adams	6	6
J Hodge	5	6

REVIEW OF VALUE FOR MONEY

As Accounting Officer, the CEO has responsibility for ensuring that the academy trust delivers good value in the use of public resources. The Accounting Officer understands that value for money refers to the educational and wider societal outcomes, as well as estates safety and management, achieved in return for the taxpayer resources received.

The Accounting Officer considers how the trust's use of its resources has provided good value for money during each academic year, and reports to the Board of Trustees where value for money can be improved, including the use of benchmarking data where available.

The Accounting Officer for the academy trust has delivered improved value for money during the year by:

- Curriculum subscriptions continue to be purchased at trust level wherever possible to maximise savings. The following are currently being used by the trust: Accelerated reader, Lexia, Read Write Inc, Kapow, Speechlink. This also allows the smaller schools to benefit from the service which they would be unable to afford as a standalone academy.

- Absence Insurance. Absence is a risk identified in the risk register and has been slowly increasing. To mitigate the risk of Long-Term absence, the trust has purchased an absence insurance policy. This was renewed in 2023/24. This also offers a wellbeing package which is anticipated will provide support and help to reduce absence going forward.

- In-house catering service. Loders Primary has been incorporated into the in-house catering service provided by the trust. All schools within the trust are now embedded into the in-house service which enables the trust to control the service and quality of meals being provided to all children. It also allows the catering manager to achieve economies of scale from larger volumes of meals being provided.

- The development of the premises team to incorporate a Business Operations Manager, Premises Manager and Handyman has enabled the trust to ensure funding is used effectively and estates are safe, well maintained and comply with regulations. By bringing the premises function fully in-house, there is better control and consistency, and the maintenance schedule is managed cost effectively with there being less reliance on external contractors.

- The hub team have continued to refine processes and procedures for central services. This incorporates utilising free services such as google forms and trello boards, creating shared folders, thus reducing the requirement to purchase external software platforms where services can be managed in house.

- The trust has been working closely with The First Federation Trust to ensure services are not unnecessarily duplicated when the trust transfers. Examples include the accounting system, educational services, and support services such as payroll, audit and legal services.

THE PURPOSE OF THE SYSTEM OF INTERNAL CONTROL

The system of internal control is designed to manage risk to a reasonable level rather than to eliminate all risk of failure to achieve policies, aims and objectives. It can, therefore, only provide reasonable and not absolute assurance of effectiveness. The system of internal control is based on an on-going process designed to identify and prioritise the risks to the achievement of academy trust policies, aims and objectives, to evaluate the likelihood of those risks being realised and the impact should they be realised, and to manage them efficiently, effectively and economically. The system of internal control has been in place in Acorn Multi Academy Trust for the period 1 September 2023 to 31 August 2024 and up to the date of approval of the annual report and financial statements.

CAPACITY TO HANDLE RISK

The Board of Trustees has reviewed the key risks to which the academy trust is exposed together with the operating, financial and compliance controls that have been implemented to mitigate those risks. The Board of Trustees is of the view that there is a formal on-going process for identifying, evaluating and managing the Academy Trust's significant risks that has been in place for the period 1 September 2023 to 31 August 2024 and up to the date of approval of the annual report and financial statements. This process is regularly reviewed by the Board of Trustees.

THE RISK AND CONTROL FRAMEWORK

The Academy Trust's system of internal financial control is based on a framework of regular management information and administrative procedures including the segregation of duties and a system of delegation and accountability. In particular it includes:

- comprehensive budgeting and monitoring systems with an annual budget and periodic financial reports which are reviewed and agreed by the Board of Trustees;
- regular reviews by the finance and audit committee of reports which indicate financial performance against the forecasts and of major purchase plans, capital works and expenditure programmes;
- setting targets to measure financial and other performance;
- clearly defined purchasing (asset purchase or capital investment) guidelines;
- delegation of authority and segregation of duties;
- identification and management of risks.

The Board of Trustees has considered the need for a specific internal audit function and has appointed Thompson Jenner as internal auditor.

The internal auditor's role includes giving advice on financial and other matters and performing a range of checks on the academy trust's financial and other systems. In particular, the checks carried out in the current period included:

- Risk management
- Policies
- Income Sources and Recognition
- Purchase Cycle, Authorisation and Value for Money
- Payroll Processes and Controls

An internal audit exercise is performed twice a year. A report is provided to the board of Trustees, through the finance and audit committee of findings of each visit outlining the areas reviewed, key findings, recommendations and conclusions to help the committee consider actions and assess year on year progress. An annual program of works is reviewed and proposed by the finance and audit committee.

REVIEW OF EFFECTIVENESS

As Accounting Officer, the CEO has responsibility for reviewing the effectiveness of the system of internal control. During the year in question the review has been informed by:

- the work of the external auditor
- the work of the internal auditor
- the financial management and governance self-assessment process or the school resource management self-assessment tool
- the work of the executive managers within the academy trust who have responsibility for the
- development and maintenance of the internal control framework.

The Accounting Officer has been advised of the implications of the result of their review of the system of internal control by the Finance and Audit Committee and a plan to address weaknesses and ensure continuous improvement of the system is in place.

CONCLUSION

Based on the advice of the finance and audit committee and the accounting officer, the Board of Trustees is of the opinion that the Trust has an adequate and effective framework for governance, risk management and control.

Approved by order of the members of the Board of Trustees on 17th December 2024 and signed on its behalf by:

A Rice

Mr B Impey
Chair of Trustees

Mrs A Rice
Accounting Officer

STATEMENT ON REGULARITY, PROPRIETY AND COMPLIANCE

As accounting officer of Acorn Multi Academy Trust I have considered my responsibility to notify the Academy Board of Trustees and the Education and Skills Funding Agency (ESFA) of material irregularity, impropriety and non-compliance with terms and conditions of all funding, including for estates safety and management, under the funding agreement between the Academy and the Secretary of State for Education. As part of my consideration I have had due regard to the requirements of the Academy Trust Handbook 2023, including responsibilities for estates safety and management.

I confirm that I and the Academy Trust Board of Trustees are able to identify any material irregular or improper use of all funds by the Academy, or material non-compliance with the terms and conditions of funding under the Academy's funding agreement and the Academy Trust Handbook 2023.

I confirm that no instances of material irregularity, impropriety or funding non-compliance have been discovered to date. If any instances are identified after the date of this statement, these will be notified to the Board of Trustees and ESFA.

A Rice

Mrs A Rice
Accounting Officer

Date: 17 December 2024

STATEMENT OF TRUSTEES' RESPONSIBILITIES FOR THE YEAR ENDED 31 AUGUST 2024

The Trustees (who are also the directors of the charitable company for the purposes of company law) are responsible for preparing the Trustees' Report and governance statement and the financial statements in accordance with the Academies Accounts Direction published by the Education and Skills Funding Agency, United Kingdom Accounting Standards (United Kingdom Generally Accepted Accounting Practice) and applicable law and regulations.

Company law requires the Trustees to prepare financial statements for each financial year. Under company law, the Trustees must not approve the financial statements unless they are satisfied that they give a true and fair view of the state of affairs of the charitable company and of its incoming resources and application of resources, including its income and expenditure, for that period. In preparing these financial statements, the Trustees are required to:

- select suitable accounting policies and then apply them consistently;
- observe the methods and principles of the Charities SORP 2019 and the Academies Accounts Direction 2023 to 2024;
- make judgments and accounting estimates that are reasonable and prudent;
- state whether applicable UK Accounting Standards have been followed, subject to any material departures disclosed and explained in the financial statements;
- prepare the financial statements on the going concern basis unless it is inappropriate to presume that the charitable company will continue in business.

The Trustees are responsible for keeping adequate accounting records that are sufficient to show and explain the charitable company's transactions and disclose with reasonable accuracy at any time the financial position of the charitable company and enable them to ensure that the financial statements comply with the Companies Act 2006. They are also responsible for safeguarding the assets of the charitable company and hence for taking reasonable steps for the prevention and detection of fraud and other irregularities.

The Trustees are responsible for ensuring that in its conduct and operation the charitable company applies financial and other controls, which conform with the requirements both of propriety and of good financial management. They are also responsible for ensuring grants received from ESFA/DfE have been applied for the purposes intended.

The Trustees are responsible for the maintenance and integrity of the corporate and financial information included on the charitable company's website. Legislation in the United Kingdom governing the preparation and dissemination of financial statements may differ from legislation in other jurisdictions.

Approved by order of the members of the Board of Trustees on 17 December 2024 and signed on its behalf by:

Mr B Impey
Chair of Trustees

INDEPENDENT AUDITORS' REPORT ON THE FINANCIAL STATEMENTS TO THE MEMBERS OF ACORN MULTI ACADEMY TRUST

Opinion

We have audited the financial statements of Acorn Multi Academy Trust (the 'Academy') for the year ended 31 August 2024 which comprise the Statement of Financial Activities (incorporating the income and expenditure account), the Balance Sheet, the Statement of Cash Flows and the related notes, including a summary of significant accounting policies. The financial reporting framework that has been applied in their preparation is applicable law, United Kingdom Accounting Standards (United Kingdom Generally Accepted Accounting Practice), including Financial Reporting Standard 102 'The Financial Reporting Standard applicable in the UK and Republic of Ireland', the Charities SORP 2019 and the Academies Accounts Direction 2023 to 2024 issued by the Education and Skills Funding Agency.

In our opinion the financial statements:

- give a true and fair view of the state of the Academy Trust's affairs as at 31 August 2024 and of its incoming resources and application of resources, including its income and expenditure for the year then ended;
- have been properly prepared in accordance with United Kingdom Generally Accepted Accounting Practice; and
- *have been prepared in accordance with the requirements of the Companies Act 2006, the Charities SORP* 2019 and the Academies Accounts Direction 2023 to 2024 issued by the Education and Skills Funding Agency.

Basis for opinion

We conducted our audit in accordance with International Standards on Auditing (UK) (ISAs (UK)) and applicable law. Our responsibilities under those standards are further described in the Auditors' responsibilities for the audit of the financial statements section of our report. We are independent of the Academy Trust in accordance with the ethical requirements that are relevant to our audit of the financial statements in the United Kingdom, including the Financial Reporting Council's Ethical Standard, and we have fulfilled our other ethical responsibilities in accordance with these requirements. We believe that the audit evidence we have obtained is sufficient and appropriate to provide a basis for our opinion.

Emphasis of matter - Financial statements prepared on a basis other than going concern

We draw attention to note 1.2 in the financial statements, which explains that the Trustees have transferred all assets, liabilities and activities of the Academy Trust into The First Federation Trust on 1 September 2024. Following this transfer, Acorn Multi Academy Trust has ceased all activities. Accordingly, the accounts have been prepared on a basis other than a going concern. Our opinion is not modified in respect of this matter.

Other information

The other information comprises the information included in the Annual report and financial statements other than the financial statements and our Auditors' Report thereon. The Trustees are responsible for the other information contained within the Annual report and financial statements. Our opinion on the financial statements does not cover the other information and, except to the extent otherwise explicitly stated in our report, we do not express any form of assurance conclusion thereon. Our responsibility is to read the other information and, in doing so, consider whether the other information is materially inconsistent with the financial statements or our knowledge obtained in the course of the audit, or otherwise appears to be materially misstated. If we identify such material inconsistencies or apparent material misstatements, we are required to determine whether this gives rise to a material misstatement in the financial statements themselves. If, based on the work we have performed, we conclude that there is a material misstatement of this other information, we are required to report that fact.

We have nothing to report in this regard.

Opinion on other matters prescribed by the Companies Act 2006

In our opinion, based on the work undertaken in the course of the audit:

- the information given in the Trustees' Report and governance statement including the Strategic Report for the financial year for which the financial statements are prepared is consistent with the financial statements.
- the Trustees' Report and governance statement and the Strategic Report have been prepared in accordance with applicable legal requirements.

Matters on which we are required to report by exception

In the light of our knowledge and understanding of the Academy Trust and its environment obtained in the course of the audit, we have not identified material misstatements in the Trustees' Report and governance statement including the Strategic Report.

We have nothing to report in respect of the following matters in relation to which the Companies Act 2006 requires us to report to you if, in our opinion:

- adequate accounting records have not been kept, or returns adequate for our audit have not been received from branches not visited by us; or
- the financial statements are not in agreement with the accounting records and returns; or
- certain disclosures of Trustees' remuneration specified by law are not made; or
- we have not received all the information and explanations we require for our audit.

Responsibilities of trustees

As explained more fully in the Statement of Trustees' Responsibilities, the Trustees (who are also the directors of the Academy for the purposes of company law) are responsible for the preparation of the financial statements and for being satisfied that they give a true and fair view, and for such internal control as the Trustees determine is necessary to enable the preparation of financial statements that are free from material misstatement, whether due to fraud or error.

In preparing the financial statements, the Trustees are responsible for assessing the Academy Trust's ability to continue as a going concern, disclosing, as applicable, matters related to going concern and using the going concern basis of accounting unless the Trustees either intend to liquidate the Academy Trust or to cease operations, or have no realistic alternative but to do so.

Auditors' responsibilities for the audit of the financial statements

Our objectives are to obtain reasonable assurance about whether the financial statements as a whole are free from material misstatement, whether due to fraud or error, and to issue an Auditors' Report that includes our opinion. Reasonable assurance is a high level of assurance, but is not a guarantee that an audit conducted in accordance with ISAs (UK) will always detect a material misstatement when it exists. Misstatements can arise from fraud or error and are considered material if, individually or in the aggregate, they could reasonably be expected to influence the economic decisions of users taken on the basis of these financial statements.

Irregularities, including fraud, are instances of non-compliance with laws and regulations. We design procedures in line with our responsibilities, outlined above, to detect material misstatements in respect of irregularities, including fraud. The extent to which our procedures are capable of detecting irregularities, including fraud is detailed below.

In identifying and assessing risks of material misstatement in respect of irregularities, including fraud and non-compliance with laws and regulations, we considered the following:

- the nature of the academy sector, control environment and the Academy Trust's performance;
- results of our enquiries of management and the Trustee board, including the committees charged with governance over the Academy Trust's finance and control, about their own identification and assessment of the risks of irregularities;
- any matters we identified having obtained and reviewed the Academy Trust's documentation of their policies and procedures relating to: identifying, evaluating and complying with laws and regulations and whether they were aware of any instances of non-compliance; detecting and responding to the risks of fraud and whether they have knowledge of any actual, suspected or alleged fraud; the internal controls established to mitigate risks of fraud or non-compliance with laws and regulations; and assessment of the impact of schools joining the Academy Trust in relation to these areas;
- how the Academy Trust ensured it met its obligations arising from it being financed by the ESFA and other funders, and as such material compliance with these obligations is required to ensure the Academy Trust will continue to receive its public funding and be authorised to operate, including around ensuring there is no material unauthorised use of funds and expenditure;
- how the Academy Trust ensured it met its obligations to its principal regulator, the Secretary of State for Education; and
- these matters were discussed among the audit engagement team who also considered any potential indicators of fraud.

As a result of these procedures, we considered the opportunities and incentives that may exist within the Academy Trust for fraud, which included incorrect recognition of revenue, management override of controls using manual journal entries, procurement and payroll. We identified the greatest potential for fraud as incorrect recognition of revenue and management override using manual journal entries.

In common with all audits under ISAs (UK), we are also required to perform specific procedures to respond to the risk of management override. We also obtained an understanding of the legal and regulatory frameworks that the Academy Trust operates in, focusing on provisions of those laws and regulations that had a direct effect on the determination of material amounts and disclosures in the financial statements. The key laws and regulations we considered in this context included the Academies Accounts Direction, Academies Financial Handbook, UK Companies Act, tax legislation and Charity SORP 2019 and FRS102.

In addition, we considered provisions of other laws and regulations that do not have a direct effect on the financial statements but compliance with which may be fundamental to the Academy Trust's ability to operate or to avoid a material penalty. These included safeguarding regulations, data protection regulations, occupational health and safety regulations, education and inspections legislation, building legislation and employment legislation.

Our procedures to respond to risks identified included the following:

- reviewing the financial statement disclosures and testing to supporting documentation to assess compliance with provisions of relevant laws and regulations described as having a direct effect on the financial statements;
- reviewing the financial statement disclosures and testing to supporting documentation to assess the recognition of revenue;
- enquiring of Trustees and management and those charged with governance concerning actual and potential litigation and claims;
- performing procedures to confirm material compliance with the requirements of its regulators;
- performing analytical procedures to identify any unusual or unexpected relationships that may indicate risks of material misstatement due to fraud;
- reading minutes of meetings of those charged with governance and reviewing internal control reports; and
- in addressing the risk of fraud through management override of controls, testing the appropriateness of journal entries and other adjustments; and assessing whether the judgements made in making accounting estimates are indicative of a potential bias.

We also communicated relevant identified laws and regulations and potential fraud risks to all engagement team members, and remained alert to any indications of fraud or non-compliance with laws and regulations throughout the audit.

Our audit procedures were designed to respond to risks of material misstatement in the financial statements, recognising that the risk of not detecting a material misstatement due to fraud is higher than the risk of not detecting one resulting from an error, as fraud may involve deliberate concealment by, for example, forgery, misrepresentations or through collusion. There are inherent limitations in the audit procedures performed and the further removed non-compliance with laws and regulations is from the events and transactions reflected in the financial statements, the less likely we would become aware of it.

A further description of our responsibilities for the audit of the financial statements is located on the Financial Reporting Council's website at: www.frc.org.uk/auditorsresponsibilities. This description forms part of our Auditors' Report.

Use of our report

This report is made solely to the Academy's members, as a body, in accordance with Chapter 3 of Part 16 of the Companies Act 2006. Our audit work has been undertaken so that we might state to the Academy's members those matters we are required to state to them in an Auditors' Report and for no other purpose. To the fullest extent permitted by law, we do not accept or assume responsibility to anyone other than the Academy and its members, as a body, for our audit work, for this report, or for the opinions we have formed.

Bishop Fleming LLP

Charles Martin ACA (Senior Statutory Auditor)
for and on behalf of
Bishop Fleming LLP
Chartered Accountants
Statutory Auditors
Salt Quay House
4 North East Quay
Sutton Harbour
Plymouth
PL4 0BN

20 December 2024

INDEPENDENT REPORTING ACCOUNTANT'S ASSURANCE REPORT ON REGULARITY TO ACORN MULTI ACADEMY TRUST AND THE EDUCATION & SKILLS FUNDING AGENCY

In accordance with the terms of our engagement letter dated 14 July 2021 and further to the requirements of the Education and Skills Funding Agency (ESFA) as included in the Academies Accounts Direction 2023 to 2024, we have carried out an engagement to obtain limited assurance about whether the expenditure disbursed and income received by Acorn Multi Academy Trust during the year 1 September 2023 to 31 August 2024 have been applied to the purposes identified by Parliament and the financial transactions conform to the authorities which govern them.

This report is made solely to Acorn Multi Academy Trust and ESFA in accordance with the terms of our engagement letter. Our work has been undertaken so that we might state to Acorn Multi Academy Trust and ESFA those matters we are required to state in a report and for no other purpose. To the fullest extent permitted by law, we do not accept or assume responsibility to anyone other than Acorn Multi Academy Trust and ESFA, for our work, for this report, or for the conclusion we have formed.

Respective responsibilities of Acorn Multi Academy Trust's accounting officer and the reporting accountant

The accounting officer is responsible, under the requirements of Acorn Multi Academy Trust's funding agreement with the Secretary of State for Education dated 1 July 2014 and the Academy Trust Handbook, extant from 1 September 2023, for ensuring that expenditure disbursed and income received is applied for the purposes intended by Parliament and the financial transactions conform to the authorities which govern them.

Our responsibilities for this engagement are established in the United Kingdom by our profession's ethical guidance and are to obtain limited assurance and report in accordance with our engagement letter and the requirements of the Academies Accounts Direction 2023 to 2024. We report to you whether anything has come to our attention in carrying out our work which suggests that in all material respects, expenditure disbursed and income received during the year 1 September 2023 to 31 August 2024 have not been applied to purposes intended by Parliament or that the financial transactions do not conform to the authorities which govern them.

Approach

We conducted our engagement in accordance with the Framework and Guide for External Auditors and Reporting Accountant of Academy Trusts issued by ESFA. We performed a limited assurance engagement as defined in our engagement letter.

The objective of a limited assurance engagement is to perform such procedures as to obtain information and explanations in order to provide us with sufficient appropriate evidence to express a negative conclusion on regularity.

A limited assurance engagement is more limited in scope than a reasonable assurance engagement and consequently does not enable us to obtain assurance that we would become aware of all significant matters that might be identified in a reasonable assurance engagement. Accordingly, we do not express a positive opinion.

Our engagement includes examination, on a test basis, of evidence relevant to the regularity and propriety of the Academy's income and expenditure.

The work undertaken to draw our conclusion includes:

An assessment of the risk of material irregularity and impropriety across all of the Trust's activities;

Further testing and review of the areas identified through the risk assessment including enquiry, identification of controls processes and examination of supporting evidence across all areas identified as well as additional verification work where considered necessary; and

Consideration of evidence obtained through the work detailed above and the work completed as part of our audit of the financial statements in order to support the regularity conclusion.

In line with the Framework and guide for external auditors and reporting accountants of academy trusts issued March 2024, we have not performed any additional procedures regarding the Trust's compliance with safeguarding, health and safety and estates management.

INDEPENDENT REPORTING ACCOUNTANT'S ASSURANCE REPORT ON REGULARITY TO ACORN MULTI ACADEMY TRUST AND THE EDUCATION & SKILLS FUNDING AGENCY (CONTINUED)

Conclusion

In the course of our work, nothing has come to our attention which suggest in all material respects the expenditure disbursed and income received during the year 1 September 2023 to 31 August 2024 has not been applied to purposes intended by Parliament and the financial transactions do not conform to the authorities which govern them.

Bishop Fleming LLP

Bishop Fleming LLP
Chartered Accountants
Statutory Auditors

Salt Quay House
4 North East Quay
Sutton Harbour
Plymouth
PL4 0BN

Date: 20 December 2024

STATEMENT OF FINANCIAL ACTIVITIES (INCORPORATING INCOME AND EXPENDITURE ACCOUNT) FOR THE YEAR ENDED 31 AUGUST 2024

	Note	Unrestricted funds 2024 £	Restricted funds 2024 £	Restricted fixed asset funds 2024 £	Total funds 2024 £	Total funds 2023 £
Income from:						
Donations and capital grants	3	**23,673**	**214,000**	**3,101,812**	**3,339,485**	1,590,560
Other trading activities		**38,361**	**-**	**-**	**38,361**	31,644
Investments	6	**15,194**	**-**	**-**	**15,194**	3,008
Charitable activities		**251,033**	**5,199,910**	**-**	**5,450,943**	4,939,660
Total income		**328,261**	**5,413,910**	**3,101,812**	**8,843,983**	6,564,872
Expenditure on:						
Charitable activities		**361,098**	**6,427,512**	**146,615**	**6,935,225**	5,711,037
Total expenditure		**361,098**	**6,427,512**	**146,615**	**6,935,225**	5,711,037
Net income /(expenditure)		**(32,837)**	**(1,013,602)**	**2,955,197**	**1,908,758**	853,835
Transfers between funds	18	**-**	**199,582**	**(199,582)**	**-**	-
Net movement in funds before other recognised gains/(losses)		**(32,837)**	**(814,020)**	**2,755,615**	**1,908,758**	853,835
Other recognised (losses):						
Actuarial (losses)/gains on defined benefit pension schemes	24	**(3,000)**	**117,000**	**-**	**114,000**	430,000
Net movement in funds		**(35,837)**	**(697,020)**	**2,755,615**	**2,022,758**	1,283,835
Reconciliation of funds:						
Total funds brought forward		**277,688**	**594,656**	**5,142,716**	**6,015,060**	4,731,225
Net movement in funds		**(35,837)**	**(697,020)**	**2,755,615**	**2,022,758**	1,283,835
Total funds carried forward		**241,851**	**(102,364)**	**7,898,331**	**8,037,818**	6,015,060

The Statement of Financial Activities includes all gains and losses recognised in the year.
The notes on pages 31 to 65 form part of these financial statements.

ACORN MULTI ACADEMY TRUST
(A COMPANY LIMITED BY GUARANTEE)
REGISTERED NUMBER:09253218

BALANCE SHEET
AS AT 31 AUGUST 2024

	Note		2024 £		2023 £
Fixed assets					
Tangible assets	14		**7,530,887**		4,478,880
Current assets					
Debtors	15	**300,689**		1,206,719	
Cash at bank and in hand		**983,289**		1,276,945	
		1,283,978		2,483,664	
Creditors: amounts falling due within one year	16	**(645,047)**		(644,484)	
Net current assets			**638,931**		1,839,180
Total assets less current liabilities			**8,169,818**		6,318,060
Defined benefit pension scheme liability	24		**(132,000)**		(303,000)
Total net assets			**8,037,818**		6,015,060
Funds of the Academy					
Restricted funds:					
Fixed asset funds	18	**7,898,331**		5,142,716	
Restricted income funds	18	**26,636**		897,656	
Restricted funds excluding pension asset	18	**7,924,967**		6,040,372	
Pension reserve	18	**(132,000)**		(303,000)	
Total restricted funds	18		**7,792,967**		5,737,372
Unrestricted income funds	18		**244,851**		277,688
Total funds			**8,037,818**		6,015,060

The financial statements on pages 28 to 65 were approved by the Trustees, and authorised for issue on 17 December 2024 and are signed on their behalf, by:

Mr B Impey
Chair of Trustees

The notes on pages 31 to 65 form part of these financial statements.

ACORN MULTI ACADEMY TRUST
(A COMPANY LIMITED BY GUARANTEE)

STATEMENT OF CASH FLOWS
FOR THE YEAR ENDED 31 AUGUST 2024

	Note	2024 £	2023 £
Cash flows from operating activities			
Net cash provided by operating activities	20	**230,021**	38,306
Cash flows from investing activities	21	**(523,677)**	243,590
Change in cash and cash equivalents in the year		**(293,656)**	281,896
Cash and cash equivalents at the beginning of the year		**1,276,945**	995,049
Cash and cash equivalents at the end of the year	22, 23	**983,289**	1,276,945

The notes on pages 31 to 65 form part of these financial statements

1. ACCOUNTING POLICIES

A summary of the principal accounting policies adopted (which have been applied consistently, except where noted), judgments and key sources of estimation uncertainty, is set out below.

1.1 BASIS OF PREPARATION OF FINANCIAL STATEMENTS

The financial statements of the Academy Trust, which is a public benefit entity under FRS 102, have been prepared under the historic cost convention in accordance with the Financial Reporting Standard Applicable in the UK and Republic of Ireland (FRS 102), the Accounting and Reporting by Charities: Statement of Recommended Practice applicable to charities preparing their accounts in accordance with the Financial Reporting Standard applicable in the UK and Republic of Ireland (FRS 102) (Charities SORP (FRS 102)), the Academies Accounts Direction 2023 to 2024 issued by ESFA, the Charities Act 2011 and the Companies Act 2006.

1.2 GOING CONCERN

The Trustees assess whether the use of going concern is appropriate i.e whether there are any material uncertainties related to events or conditions that may cast significant doubt on the ability of the Academy Trust to continue as a going concern. The Trustees make this assessment in respect of a period of at least one year from the date of authorisation for issue of the financial statements.

On 1 September 2024, the Academy Trust joined The First Federation Trust, another multi academy trust, at which point all of the assets, liabilities and activities of the Academy Trust were transferred to The First Federation Trust. From this date, this Academy Trust has ceased all activities. Accordingly, the accounts have been prepared on a basis other than as a going concern. However, given that the Academy Trust will be carried on by a multi academy trust, no adjustments to, or reclassifications of, the amounts included in these accounts prior to transfer have been required.

1. ACCOUNTING POLICIES (continued)

1.3 INCOME

All incoming resources are recognised when the Academy has entitlement to the funds, the receipt is probable and the amount can be measured reliably.

- **Grants**

  Grants are included in the Statement of Financial Activities on a receivable basis. The balance of income received for specific purposes but not expended during the period is shown in the relevant funds on the Balance Sheet. Where income is received in advance of meeting any performance-related conditions there is not unconditional entitlement to the income and its recognition is deferred and included in creditors as deferred income until the performance-related conditions are met. Where entitlement occurs before income is received, the income is accrued.

  General Annual Grant is recognised in full in the Statement of Financial Activities in the year for which it is receivable and any abatement in respect of the year is deducted from income and recognised as a liability.

  Capital grants are recognised in full when there is an unconditional entitlement to the grant. Unspent amounts of capital grants are reflected in the Balance Sheet in the restricted fixed asset fund. Capital grants are recognised when there is entitlement and are not deferred over the life of the asset on which they are expended.

- **Donations**

  Donations are recognised on a receivable basis (where there are no performance-related conditions) where the receipt is probable and the amount can be reliably measured.

- **Other income**

  Other income, including the hire of facilities, is recognised in the year it is receivable and to the extent the Academy has provided the goods or services.

1. ACCOUNTING POLICIES (continued)

1.4 EXPENDITURE

Expenditure is recognised once there is a legal or constructive obligation to transfer economic benefit to a third party, it is probable that a transfer of economic benefits will be required in settlement and the amount of the obligation can be measured reliably. Expenditure is classified by activity. The costs of each activity are made up of the total of direct costs and shared costs, including support costs involved in undertaking each activity. Direct costs attributable to a single activity are allocated directly to that activity. Shared costs which contribute to more than one activity and support costs which are not attributable to a single activity are apportioned between those activities on a basis consistent with the use of resources. Central staff costs are allocated on the basis of time spent, and depreciation charges allocated on the portion of the asset's use.

- **Charitable activities**
  These are costs incurred on the Academy's educational operations, including support costs and costs relating to the governance of the Academy apportioned to charitable activities.

- **Grants payable**
  These are charged in the year when the offer is made except in those cases where the offer is conditional, such grants being recognised as expenditure when the conditions attaching are fulfilled. Grants offered subject to conditions which have not been met at the year end are noted as a commitment, but not accrued as expenditure.

All resources expended are inclusive of irrecoverable VAT.

1.5 INTEREST RECEIVABLE

Interest on funds held on deposit is included when receivable and the amount can be measured reliably by the Academy; this is normally upon notification of the interest paid or payable by the institution with whom the funds are deposited.

1.6 TAXATION

The Academy is considered to pass the tests set out in Paragraph 1 Schedule 6 of the Finance Act 2010 and therefore it meets the definition of a charitable company for UK corporation tax purposes.

Accordingly, the Academy is potentially exempt from taxation in respect of income or capital gains received within categories covered by Part 11, chapter 3 of the Corporation Tax Act 2010 or Section 256 of the Taxation of Chargeable Gains Act 1992, to the extent that such income or gains are applied exclusively to charitable purposes.

1. ACCOUNTING POLICIES (continued)

1.7 TANGIBLE FIXED ASSETS

Assets costing £2,000 or more are capitalised as tangible fixed assets and are carried at cost, net of depreciation and any provision for impairment.

Where tangible fixed assets have been acquired with the aid of specific grants, either from the government or from the private sector, they are included in the Balance Sheet at cost and depreciated over their expected useful economic life. Where there are specific conditions attached to the funding requiring the continued use of the asset, the related grants are credited to a restricted fixed asset fund in the Statement of Financial Activities and carried forward in the Balance Sheet. Depreciation on the relevant assets is charged directly to the restricted fixed asset fund in the Statement of Financial Activities. Where tangible fixed assets have been acquired with unrestricted funds, depreciation on such assets is charged to the unrestricted fund.

Depreciation is provided on all tangible fixed assets other than freehold land and assets under construction, at rates calculated to write off the cost of each asset on a straight-line basis over its expected useful life, as follows:

The estimated useful lives are as follows:

Leasehold land and buildings	- 125 years straight line
Leasehold improvements	- 25 years straight line
Furniture and equipment	- 5 years straight line
Computer equipment	- 4 years straight line

A review for impairment of a fixed asset is carried out if events or changes in circumstances indicate that the carrying value of any fixed asset may not be recoverable. Shortfalls between the carrying value of fixed assets and their recoverable amounts are recognised as impairments. Impairment losses are recognised in the Statement of Financial Activities.

Where the Academy Trust has been granted use of the school buildings from the Diocese under Supplemental Agreements, the Academies Accounts Direction prescribes that under this agreement the risks and rewards of ownership remain with the Diocese. A donation from the Diocese has been recognised equal to the deemed rental expense, based on the rateable value of the buildings.

The Academy Trust's occupation for the period is recognisable as a notional donation (since it pays no actual rent) and a notional rental expense for its use of the premises. The value of the donation is the amount that the Academy Trust would otherwise have to pay to secure the premises for its operations.

Capital improvements to the Diocesan property occupied by the Academy Trust is recognised as grant expenditure.

1.8 DEBTORS

Trade and other debtors with no stated interest rate and due within one year are recorded at the amount of the cash or other consideration expected to be received. Prepayments are valued at the amount paid.

1.9 CASH AT BANK AND IN HAND

Cash at bank and in hand includes cash and short-term highly liquid investments with a short maturity of three months or less from the date of acquisition or opening of the deposit or similar account.

1. ACCOUNTING POLICIES (continued)

1.10 LIABILITIES

Liabilities are recognised when there is an obligation at the Balance Sheet date as a result of a past event, it is probable that a transfer of economic benefit will be required in settlement, and the amount of the settlement can be estimated reliably. Liabilities are recognised at the amount that the Academy Trust anticipates it will pay to settle the debt or the amount it has received as advanced payments for the goods or services it must provide.

1.11 FINANCIAL INSTRUMENTS

The Academy Trust only holds basic financial instruments as defined in FRS 102. The financial assets and financial liabilities of the Academy trust and their measurement bases are as follows:

Financial assets - trade and other debtors are basic financial instruments and are debt instruments measured at amortised cost as detailed in note 15. Prepayments are not financial instruments.

Cash at bank is classified as a basic financial instrument and is measured at face value.

Financial liabilities - trade creditors, accruals and other creditors are financial instruments, and are measured at amortised cost as detailed in note 16. Taxation and social security are not included in the financial instruments disclosure definition. Deferred income is not deemed to be a financial liability, as the cash settlement has already taken place and there is an obligation to deliver services rather than cash or another financial instrument.

1.12 OPERATING LEASES

Rentals paid under operating leases are charged to the Statement of Financial Activities on a straight-line basis over the lease term.

1. ACCOUNTING POLICIES (continued)

1.13 PENSIONS

Retirement benefits to employees of the Academy Trust Trust are provided by the Teachers' Pension Scheme ("TPS") and the Local Government Pension Scheme ("LGPS"). These are defined benefit schemes.

The TPS is an unfunded scheme and contributions are calculated so as to spread the cost of pensions over employees' working lives with the Academy Trust in such a way that the pension cost is a substantially level percentage of current and future pensionable payroll. The contributions are determined by the Government Actuary on the basis of quadrennial valuations using a prospective unit credit method. TPS is an unfunded multi-employer scheme with no underlying assets to assign between employers. Consequently, the TPS is treated as a defined contribution scheme for accounting purposes and the contributions recognised in the period to which they relate.

The LGPS is a funded multi-employer scheme and the assets are held separately from those of the Academy Trust in separate trustee administered funds. Pension scheme assets are measured at fair value and liabilities are measured on an actuarial basis using the projected unit credit method and discounted at a rate equivalent to the current rate of return on a high quality corporate bond of equivalent term and currency to the liabilities. The actuarial valuations are obtained at least triennially and are updated at each Balance Sheet date. The amounts charged to operating surplus are the current service costs and the costs of scheme introductions, benefit changes, settlements and curtailments. They are included as part of staff costs as incurred. Net interest on the net defined benefit liability/asset is also recognised in the Statement of Financial Activities and comprises the interest cost on the defined benefit obligation and interest income on the scheme assets, calculated by multiplying the fair value of the scheme assets at the beginning of the period by the rate used to discount the benefit obligations. The difference between the interest income on the scheme assets and the actual return on the scheme assets is recognised in other recognised gains and losses.

Actuarial gains and losses are recognised immediately in other recognised gains and losses.

1.14 FUND ACCOUNTING

Unrestricted income funds represent those resources which may be used towards meeting any of the charitable objects of the Academy Trust at the discretion of the Trustees.

Restricted fixed asset funds are resources which are to be applied to specific capital purposes imposed by the funders where the asset acquired or created is held for a specific purpose.

Restricted general funds comprise all other restricted funds received with restrictions imposed by the funder/donor and include grants from the Department for Education Group.

Investment income, gains and losses are allocated to the appropriate fund.

2. CRITICAL ACCOUNTING ESTIMATES AND AREAS OF JUDGMENT

Estimates and judgments are continually evaluated and are based on historical experience and other factors, including expectations of future events that are believed to be reasonable under the circumstances.

Critical accounting estimates and assumptions:

The Academy Trust makes estimates and assumptions concerning the future. The resulting accounting estimates and assumptions will, by definition, seldom equal the related actual results. The estimates and assumptions that have a significant risk of causing a material adjustment to the carrying amounts of assets and liabilities within the next financial year are discussed below.

The present value of the Local Government Pension Scheme defined benefit liability depends on a number of factors that are determined on an actuarial basis using a variety of assumptions. The assumptions used in determining the net cost or income for pensions include the discount rate. Any changes in these assumptions, which are disclosed in note 24, will impact the carrying amount of the pension liability. Furthermore a roll forward approach which projects results from the latest full actuarial valuation performed at 31 March 2022 has been used by the actuary in valuing the pensions liability at 31 August 2024. Any differences between the figures derived from the roll forward approach and a full actuarial valuation would impact on the carrying amount of the pension liability.

Critical areas of judgment:

The Academy Trust obtains use of fixed assets as a lessee. The classification of such leases as operating or finance lease requires the Academy Trust to determine, based on an evaluation of the terms and conditions of the arrangements, whether it retains or acquires the significant risks and rewards of ownership of these assets and accordingly whether the lease requires an asset and liability to be recognised in the Balance Sheet.

3. INCOME FROM DONATIONS AND CAPITAL GRANTS

	Unrestricted funds 2024 £	**Restricted funds 2024 £**	**Restricted fixed asset funds 2024 £**	**Total funds 2024 £**	Total funds 2023 £
Donations	23,673	214,000	2,571,946	**2,809,619**	240,532
Capital Grants	-	-	529,866	**529,866**	1,350,028
TOTAL 2024	23,673	214,000	3,101,812	**3,339,485**	1,590,560
TOTAL 2023	26,532	214,000	1,350,028	1,590,560	

4. FUNDING FOR THE ACADEMY'S CHARITABLE ACTIVITIES

	Unrestricted funds 2024 £	Restricted funds 2024 £	Total funds 2024 £	Total funds 2023 £
EDUCATION				
DFE/ESFA GRANTS				
General Annual Grant	-	3,999,416	**3,999,416**	3,799,594
Pupil Premium	-	228,421	**228,421**	205,900
UIFSM	-	106,718	**106,718**	98,910
PE & Sports Grant	-	112,130	**112,130**	108,900
School Supplementary Grant	-	-	**-**	106,468
Mainstream School Additional Grant	-	130,633	**130,633**	-
Other DfE/ESFA Grants	-	78,862	**78,862**	70,878
Teachers Pay Grant	-	67,720	**67,720**	3,993
	-	4,723,900	**4,723,900**	4,394,643
OTHER GOVERNMENT GRANTS				
High Needs	-	158,805	**158,805**	83,086
Nursery Funding	-	235,575	**235,575**	182,868
	-	394,380	**394,380**	265,954
Other income from the Academy's educational operations	251,033	81,630	**332,663**	198,771
COVID-19 ADDITIONAL FUNDING (ESFA & Local Authority)				
Catch up grant	-	-	**-**	80,292
	-	-	**-**	80,292
TOTAL EDUCATION	251,033	5,199,910	**5,450,943**	4,939,660
TOTAL 2023	166,789	4,772,871	4,939,660	

5. INCOME FROM OTHER TRADING ACTIVITIES

	Unrestricted funds 2024 £	Total funds 2024 £	Total funds 2023 £
Hire of facilities	-	-	300
Other income	38,361	**38,361**	31,344
TOTAL 2024	38,361	**38,361**	31,644
TOTAL 2023	31,644	31,644	

6. INVESTMENT INCOME

	Unrestricted funds 2024 £	Total funds 2024 £	Total funds 2023 £
Investment income	15,194	**15,194**	3,008
TOTAL 2023	3,008	3,008	

7. EXPENDITURE

	Staff Costs 2024 £	Premises 2024 £	Other 2024 £	Total 2024 £	Total 2023 £
EDUCATION:					
Direct costs	3,005,293	53,643	388,862	**3,447,798**	3,482,724
Allocated support costs	1,751,584	817,764	495,789	**3,065,137**	1,973,856
TOTAL 2024	4,756,877	871,407	884,651	**6,512,935**	5,456,580
TOTAL 2023	4,105,300	576,993	774,287	5,456,580	

8. ANALYSIS OF GRANTS

	Grants to Institutions 2024 £	**Total funds 2024 £**	Total funds 2023 £
Improvements to diocesan property occupied by the Academy Trust	422,290	**422,290**	254,457
TOTAL 2023	254,457	254,457	

9. ANALYSIS OF EXPENDITURE BY ACTIVITIES

	Activities undertaken directly 2024 £	**Grant funding of activities 2024 £**	**Support costs 2024 £**	**Total funds 2024 £**	Total funds 2023 £
Education	3,447,798	422,290	3,065,137	**6,935,225**	5,711,037
TOTAL 2023	3,482,724	254,457	1,973,856	5,711,037	

9. ANALYSIS OF EXPENDITURE BY ACTIVITIES (CONTINUED)

ANALYSIS OF DIRECT COSTS

	Education 2024 £	**Total funds 2024 £**	Total funds 2023 £
Pension finance costs	9,000	**9,000**	23,000
Staff costs	2,775,138	**2,775,138**	2,886,641
Depreciation	78,056	**78,056**	63,142
Educational supplies	120,266	**120,266**	70,430
Other costs	124,495	**124,495**	114,508
Supply teachers	230,155	**230,155**	199,520
Recruitment and support	4,698	**4,698**	8,624
Educational consultancy	105,990	**105,990**	116,859
	3,447,798	**3,447,798**	3,482,724
TOTAL 2023	3,482,724	3,482,724	

9. ANALYSIS OF EXPENDITURE BY ACTIVITIES (CONTINUED)

ANALYSIS OF SUPPORT COSTS

	Education 2024 £	Total funds 2024 £	Total funds 2023 £
Staff costs	1,751,584	**1,751,584**	1,019,139
Depreciation	68,559	**68,559**	39,426
Staff development	9,928	**9,928**	20,879
Other costs	39,445	**39,445**	23,518
Maintenance of premises and equipment	335,611	**335,611**	56,859
Cleaning	73,550	**73,550**	80,979
Rent and rates	275,970	**275,970**	282,705
Energy costs	114,384	**114,384**	106,946
Insurance	17,654	**17,654**	16,611
Catering	129,907	**129,907**	126,426
Technology costs	106,697	**106,697**	115,361
Office overheads	24,060	**24,060**	25,105
Legal and professional	75,599	**75,599**	19,062
Bank interest and charges	2,491	**2,491**	1,527
Educational consultancy	14,300	**14,300**	15,806
Governance costs	25,398	**25,398**	23,507
TOTAL 2024	3,065,137	**3,065,137**	1,973,856
TOTAL 2023	1,973,856	1,973,856	

10. NET (EXPENDITURE)/INCOME

Net (expenditure)/income for the year includes:

	2024 £	2023 £
Operating lease rentals	**7,316**	6,839
Depreciation of tangible fixed assets	**146,152**	102,562
Fees paid to auditors for:		
- audit	**15,750**	12,500
- other services	**2,780**	2,475

11. STAFF

a. STAFF COSTS AND EMPLOYEE BENEFITS

Staff costs during the year were as follows:

	2024	2023
	£	£
Wages and salaries	**3,331,354**	2,951,047
Social security costs	**300,287**	245,736
Pension costs	**737,032**	708,997
	4,368,673	3,905,780
Agency staff costs	**230,155**	199,520
Staff restructuring costs	**158,049**	-
	4,756,877	4,105,300

Staff restructuring costs comprise:

	2024	2023
	£	£
Redundancy payments	**158,049**	-
	158,049	-

b. STAFF NUMBERS

The average number of persons employed by the Academy during the year was as follows:

	2024	2023
	No.	No.
Teachers	**45**	55
Administration and support	**104**	96
Management	**11**	3
	160	154

11. STAFF (CONTINUED)

b. STAFF NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

The average headcount expressed as full-time equivalents was:

	2024 No.	2023 No.
Teachers	**33**	42
Administration and support	**58**	56
Management	**10**	3
	101	101

c. HIGHER PAID STAFF

The number of employees whose employee benefits (excluding employer pension costs) exceeded £60,000 was:

	2024 No.	2023 No.
In the band £60,001 - £70,000	**-**	1
In the band £70,001 - £80,000	**1**	-
In the band £110,001 - £120,000	**-**	1
In the band £230,001 - £240,000	**1**	-

d. KEY MANAGEMENT PERSONNEL

The key management personnel of the Academy comprise the Trustees and the senior management team identified as such on page 1. The total amount of employee benefits (including employer pension contributions and employer national insurance contributions) received by key management personnel for their services to the Academy was £508,823 (*2023* - £241,552).

12. TRUSTEES' REMUNERATION AND EXPENSES

One or more Trustees has been paid remuneration or has received other benefits from an employment with the Academy. The principal and other staff Trustees only receive remuneration in respect of services they provide undertaking the roles of principal and staff members under their contracts of employment. The value of Ms A Rice's (Chief Executive), remuneration was between £230,000 - £240,000 (2023: £115,000 - £120,000) and the pension contributions paid were between £30,000 - £35,000 (2023: £25,000 - £30,000).

During the year ended 31 August 2024, expenses totaling £471 were reimbursed or paid directly to 2 Trustees (2023: £1,165 to 3 Trustees.)

13. TRUSTEES' AND OFFICERS' INSURANCE

In accordance with normal commercial practice, the Academy has purchased insurance to protect Trustees and officers from claims arising from negligent acts, errors or omissions occurring whilst on academy business. The insurance provides cover up to £5,000,000 on any one claim and the cost for the year ended 31 August 2024 was £11,925 (2023: £11,925). The cost of this insurance is included in the total insurance cost.

14. TANGIBLE FIXED ASSETS

	Leasehold land and buildings £	Leasehold Impr'ments £	Furniture and equipment £	Computer equipment £	Total £
COST					
At 1 September 2023	**3,759,000**	**886,170**	**39,455**	**221,326**	**4,905,951**
Additions	**-**	**3,191,452**	**-**	**6,707**	**3,198,159**
At 31 August 2024	**3,759,000**	**4,077,622**	**39,455**	**228,033**	**8,104,110**
DEPRECIATION					
At 1 September 2023	**143,208**	**94,093**	**18,699**	**171,071**	**427,071**
Charge for the year	**16,168**	**85,512**	**5,412**	**39,060**	**146,152**
At 31 August 2024	**159,376**	**179,605**	**24,111**	**210,131**	**573,223**
NET BOOK VALUE					
At 31 August 2024	**3,599,624**	**3,898,017**	**15,344**	**17,902**	**7,530,887**
At 31 August 2023	3,615,792	792,077	20,756	50,255	4,478,880

15. DEBTORS

	2024 £	2023 £
DUE WITHIN ONE YEAR		
Trade debtors	**307**	720
Prepayments and accrued income	**263,018**	1,187,754
VAT recoverable	**37,364**	18,245
	300,689	1,206,719

16. CREDITORS: AMOUNTS FALLING DUE WITHIN ONE YEAR

	2024 £	2023 £
Trade creditors	**122,291**	104,477
Other taxation and social security	**98,691**	57,313
Other creditors	**96,684**	75,421
Accruals and deferred income	**327,381**	407,273
	645,047	644,484

	2024 £	2023 £
Deferred income at 1 September	**74,640**	69,718
Resources deferred during the year	**83,392**	74,640
Amounts released from previous periods	**(74,640)**	(69,718)
	83,392	74,640

Deferred income related to funding received for Universal Infant Free School Meals, school trips and rates relief.

17. FINANCIAL INSTRUMENTS

	2024	2023
	£	£
FINANCIAL ASSETS		
Financial assets measured at fair value through income and expenditure	**983,289**	1,276,945
Financial assets that are debt instruments measured at amortised cost	**135,631**	1,088,388
	1,118,920	2,365,333

Financial assets measured at fair value through income and expenditure comprise cash at bank and in hand.

Financial liabilities measured at amortised cost comprise trade creditors, accruals and other creditors.

18. STATEMENT OF FUNDS

	Balance at 1 September 2023 £	Income £	Expenditure £	Transfers in/out £	Gains/ (Losses) £	Balance at 31 August 2024 £
UNRESTR'D FUNDS						
General Funds	277,688	328,261	(361,098)	-	-	244,851
RESTRICTED GENERAL FUNDS						
General Annual Grant (GAG)	462,871	3,999,416	(4,462,287)	-	-	-
PE & Sport premium	-	112,130	(112,130)	-	-	-
Other DfE & ESFA grants	-	283,396	(283,396)	-	-	-
Pupil Premium	-	228,421	(228,421)	-	-	-
UIFSM	-	106,718	(106,718)	-	-	-
High Needs	-	158,805	(144,177)	-	-	14,628
Early Years Funding	-	235,575	(235,575)	-	-	-
Recovery	-	26,005	(26,005)	-	-	-
Diocese rental charge	-	214,000	(214,000)	-	-	-
Trips	-	49,444	(49,444)	-	-	-
Other restricted donations/grants	3,347	-	-	-	-	3,347
Condition improvement fund	431,438	-	(622,359)	199,582	-	8,661
Pension reserve	(303,000)	-	57,000	-	114,000	(132,000)
	594,656	5,413,910	(6,427,512)	199,582	114,000	(105,364)

18. STATEMENT OF FUNDS (CONTINUED)

	Balance at 1 September 2023 £	Income £	Expenditure £	Transfers in/out £	Gains/ (Losses) £	Balance at 31 August 2024 £
RESTRICTED FIXED ASSET FUNDS						
Transferred on conversion	3,653,628	-	(16,168)	-	-	3,637,460
DfE / Capital grants	951,895	58,042	(14,842)	(40,690)	-	954,405
Capital from predecessor school	22,730	-	(7,576)	-	-	15,154
Fixed assets purchased from GAG and other restricted funds	18,474	-	(7,474)	-	-	11,000
Condition improvement fund	495,989	471,824	(56,370)	(158,892)	-	752,551
Donated assets from LA	-	2,571,946	(44,185)	-	-	2,527,761
	5,142,716	3,101,812	(146,615)	(199,582)	-	7,898,331
TOTAL RESTRICTED FUNDS	5,737,372	8,515,722	(6,574,127)	-	114,000	7,792,967
TOTAL FUNDS	6,015,060	8,843,983	(6,935,225)	-	114,000	8,037,818

The specific purposes for which the funds are to be applied are as follows:

Restricted funds

General Annual Grant - Income from the ESFA which is to be use for the normal running costs of the Academy, including education and support costs.

PE & Sports Premium - Income from the ESFA which is to be used to fund additional and sustainable improvements to the provision of PE and sport for the benefit of primary-aged pupils.

Other DfE & ESFA Grants - Other ESFA grants received for the purpose of supporting school to school improvement.

Pupil Premium - Represents funding received from the ESFA for children that qualify for free school meals to enable the Academy to address the current underlying inequalities between those children and their wealthier peers.

UIFSM - Universal infant free school meals (UIFSM) provides funding for all government funded schools to offer free school meals to pupils in reception, year 1, and year 2.

18. STATEMENT OF FUNDS (CONTINUED)

High Needs - Funding received by the Local Authority to fund further support for students with additional needs.

Early Years Funding - Funding received by the Local Authority to fund further support for nurseries.

Recovery Premium - Government funding to be used to support pupils whose education has been affected by the significant impact of COVID-19.

Diocese land and building rent - The Trust's occupation of property owned by the Diocese of Exeter for the period is recognisable as a notional donation and a notional rental expense.

Trips - Contributions from parents towards educational visits.

Condition improvement fund - This represents the value of funding received in respect of the Condition Improvement fund that is to be used on diocese owned buildings.

Pension Reserve – This represents the academy's share of the assets and liabilities in the Local Government Pension Scheme.

Fixed Asset Funds

Fixed assets transferred on conversion – This represent the buildings and equipment donated to the school from the Local Authority on conversion to an Academy.

DfE Capital Grants & Donations - This represent funding from the ESFA to spend specifically on the Capital improvements of the Trust premises. It also includes a small amount of donated equipment. The fixed asset fund balance at the year end represents the NBV of assets and any unspent capital grants.

Capital from predecessor school - This represents an element of capital received from a predecessor school.

Fixed assets purchased from GAG and other restricted funds - This represents the NBV of assets acquired using funds transferred from the restricted GAG funds.

Condition improvement fund - This represents the value of funding received in respect of the Condition Improvement fund to keep school and college buildings safe and in good working order.

Transfers - £199,582 has been transferred to restricted general funds from the restricted fixed asset funds, representing expenditure incurred on diocese owned buildings from capital grants.

Under the funding agreement with the Secretary of State, the Academy was not subject to a limit on the amount of GAG it could carry forward at 31 August 2024.

18. STATEMENT OF FUNDS (CONTINUED)

Comparative information in respect of the preceding year is as follows:

	Balance at 1 September 2022 £	Income £	Expenditure £	Transfers in/out £	Gains/ (Losses) £	Balance at 31 August 2023 £
UNRESTRICTED FUNDS						
General funds	259,353	227,973	(209,638)	-	-	277,688
RESTRICTED GENERAL FUNDS						
General Annual Grant (GAG)	462,279	3,799,594	(3,833,315)	34,313	-	462,871
PE & Sport premium	-	108,900	(108,900)	-	-	-
Other DfE & ESFA grants	-	181,339	(181,339)	-	-	-
Pupil Premium	-	205,900	(205,900)	-	-	-
UIFSM	-	98,910	(98,910)	-	-	-
High Needs	-	83,086	(83,086)	-	-	-
Early Years Funding	-	182,868	(182,868)	-	-	-
Recovery	-	80,292	(80,292)	-	-	-
Diocese rental charge	-	214,000	(214,000)	-	-	-
Trips	4,474	31,982	(36,456)	-	-	-
Other restricted donations/grants	3,680	-	(333)	-	-	3,347
Devolved formula capital	-	-	(40,975)	40,975	-	-
Condition improvement fund	8,599	-	(254,457)	677,296	-	431,438
Pension reserve	(655,000)	-	(78,000)	-	430,000	(303,000)
	(175,968)	4,986,871	(5,398,831)	752,584	430,000	594,656

18. STATEMENT OF FUNDS (CONTINUED)

	Balance at 1 September 2022 £	Income £	Expenditure £	Transfers in/out £	Gains/ (Losses) £	Balance at 31 August 2023 £
RESTRICTED FIXED ASSET FUNDS						
Transferred on conversion	3,669,796	-	(16,168)	-	-	3,653,628
DfE / Capital grants	925,317	119,888	(14,495)	(78,815)	-	951,895
Capital from predecessor school	30,306	-	(7,576)	-	-	22,730
Fixed assets purchased from GAG and other restricted funds	22,421	-	(7,474)	3,527	-	18,474
Condition improvement fund	-	1,230,140	(56,855)	(677,296)	-	495,989
	4,647,840	1,350,028	(102,568)	(752,584)	-	5,142,716
TOTAL RESTRICTED FUNDS	4,471,872	6,336,899	(5,501,399)	-	430,000	5,737,372
TOTAL FUNDS	4,731,225	6,564,872	(5,711,037)	-	430,000	6,015,060

18. STATEMENT OF FUNDS (CONTINUED)

Total funds analysis by academy

Fund balances at 31 August 2024 were allocated as follows:

	2024	2023
	£	£
Marshwood CofE Primary Academy	**-**	324,313
St Andrew's CofE Primary Academy	**3,347**	3,347
Loders CofE Primary Academy	**8,661**	-
Thorncombe, St Mary's Church of England Primary Academy	**-**	101,127
Acorn Multi Academy Trust	**259,479**	746,557
Total before fixed asset funds and pension reserve	**271,487**	1,175,344
Restricted fixed asset fund	**7,898,331**	5,142,716
Pension reserve	**(132,000)**	(303,000)
TOTAL	**8,037,818**	6,015,060

The trust has pooled all GAG income between individual academies as well as the free reserves of each academy.

The carry forward balances of the individual academies represents ringfenced grants and restricted funding that is not eligible for pooling.

18. STATEMENT OF FUNDS (CONTINUED)

TOTAL COST ANALYSIS BY ACADEMY

Expenditure incurred by each academy during the year was as follows:

	Teaching and educational support staff costs £	Other support staff costs £	Educational supplies £	Other costs excluding depreciation £	Total 2024 £	Total 2023 £
Axminster Community Primary Academy	852,714	304,329	139,778	35,799	**1,332,620**	1,081,076
Marshwood CofE Primary Academy	219,613	104,469	101,142	5,438	**430,662**	427,917
Mrs Ethelston's CofE Primary Academy	564,135	127,377	71,576	20,902	**783,990**	712,416
St Andrew's CofE Primary Academy	295,620	174,036	59,628	12,901	**542,185**	597,033
Loders CofE Primary Academy	230,003	111,740	32,259	11,398	**385,400**	175,269
Membury Primary School	86,607	70,452	21,198	2,935	**181,192**	380,995
Thorncombe, St Mary's Church of England Primary Academy	167,741	128,154	52,744	7,181	**355,820**	315,696
Acorn Multi Academy Trust	395,703	760,027	107,277	1,513,734	**2,776,741**	1,840,073
	2,812,136	1,780,584	585,602	1,610,288	**6,788,610**	5,530,475

19. ANALYSIS OF NET ASSETS BETWEEN FUNDS

ANALYSIS OF NET ASSETS BETWEEN FUNDS - CURRENT PERIOD

	Unrestricted funds 2024 £	**Restricted funds 2024 £**	**Restricted fixed asset funds 2024 £**	**Total funds 2024 £**
Tangible fixed assets	-	-	7,530,887	**7,530,887**
Current assets	244,851	671,683	367,444	**1,283,978**
Creditors due within one year	-	(645,047)	-	**(645,047)**
Defined benefit pension scheme liability	-	(132,000)	-	**(132,000)**
TOTAL	244,851	(105,364)	7,898,331	**8,037,818**

ANALYSIS OF NET ASSETS BETWEEN FUNDS - PRIOR YEAR

	Unrestricted funds 2023 £	Restricted funds 2023 £	Restricted fixed asset funds 2023 £	Total funds 2023 £
Tangible fixed assets	-	-	4,478,880	4,478,880
Current assets	277,688	1,542,140	663,836	2,483,664
Creditors due within one year	-	(644,484)	-	(644,484)
Defined benefit pension scheme liability	-	(303,000)	-	(303,000)
TOTAL	277,688	594,656	5,142,716	6,015,060

20. RECONCILIATION OF NET INCOME TO NET CASH FLOW FROM OPERATING ACTIVITIES

	2024 £	2023 £
Net income for the period (as per Statement of Financial Activities)	**1,908,758**	853,835
ADJUSTMENTS FOR:		
Depreciation	**146,152**	102,562
Capital grants from DfE and other capital income	**(3,101,812)**	(1,350,028)
Interest receivable	**(15,194)**	(3,008)
Defined benefit pension scheme cost less contributions payable	**(66,000)**	55,000
Defined benefit pension scheme finance cost	**9,000**	23,000
Decrease in debtors	**1,401,305**	54,640
(Decrease)/increase in creditors	**(52,188)**	302,305
NET CASH PROVIDED BY OPERATING ACTIVITIES	**230,021**	38,306

21. CASH FLOWS FROM INVESTING ACTIVITIES

	2024 £	2023 £
Dividends, interest and rents from investments	**15,194**	3,008
Purchase of tangible assets	**(573,462)**	(66,473)
Capital grants from DfE Group	**34,591**	307,055
NET CASH (USED IN)/PROVIDED BY INVESTING ACTIVITIES	**(523,677)**	243,590

22. ANALYSIS OF CASH AND CASH EQUIVALENTS

	2024 £	2023 £
Cash in hand and at bank	**983,289**	1,276,945
TOTAL CASH AND CASH EQUIVALENTS	**983,289**	1,276,945

23. ANALYSIS OF CHANGES IN NET DEBT

	At 1 September 2023 £	Cash flows £	At 31 August 2024 £
Cash at bank and in hand	1,276,945	(293,656)	983,289
	1,276,945	(293,656)	983,289

24. PENSION COMMITMENTS

The Academy's employees belong to two principal pension schemes: the Teachers' Pension Scheme England and Wales (TPS) for academic and related staff; and the Local Government Pension Scheme (LGPS) for non-teaching staff, which is managed by Dorset and Devon County Council. Both are multi-employer defined benefit schemes.

The latest actuarial valuation of the TPS related to the period ended 31 March 2020 and of the LGPS 31 March 2022.

Contributions amounting to £87,280 were payable to the schemes at 31 August 2024 (2023 - £75,167) and are included within creditors.

TEACHERS' PENSION SCHEME

The Teachers' Pension Scheme (TPS) is a statutory, contributory, defined benefit scheme, governed by the Teachers' Pension Scheme Regulations 2014. Membership is automatic for full-time teachers in academies. All teachers have the option to opt-out of the TPS following enrolment.

The TPS is an unfunded scheme to which both the member and employer makes contributions, as a percentage of salary - these contributions are credited to the Exchequer. Retirement and other pension benefits are paid by public funds provided by Parliament.

24. PENSION COMMITMENTS (CONTINUED)

VALUATION OF THE TEACHERS' PENSION SCHEME

The Government Actuary, using normal actuarial principles, conducts a formal actuarial review of the TPS in accordance with the Public Service Pensions (Valuations and Employer Cost Cap) Directions 2014 published by HM Treasury every 4 years. The aim of the review is to ensure scheme costs are recognised and managed appropriately and the review specifies the level of future contributions.

Actuarial scheme valuations are dependent on assumptions about the value of future costs, design of benefits and many other factors. The latest actuarial valuation of the TPS was carried out as at 31 March 2020. The valuation report was published by the Department for Education on 27 October 2023, with the SCAPE rate, set by HMT, applying a notional investment return based on 1.7% above the rate of CPI. The key elements of the valuation outcome are:

- employer contribution rates set at 28.6% of pensionable pay (including a 0.08% administration levy)
- total scheme liabilities (pensions currently in payment and the estimated cost of future benefits) for service to the effective date of £262,100 million and notional assets (estimated future contributions together with the notional investments held at the valuation date) of £222,200 million, giving a notional past service deficit of £39,800 million

The 2020 valuation result is due to be implemented from 1 April 2024 and effective until 31 March 2027. The employer contribution rate for this period will be 28.68% of pensionable pay (including a 0.08% administration levy).

The employer's pension costs paid to TPS in the year amounted to £470,440 (2023 - £384,997).

A copy of the valuation report and supporting documentation is on the Teachers' Pensions website (https://www.teacherspensions.co.uk/news/employers/2019/04/teachers-pensions-valuation-report.aspx) for 2016 and www.teacherspensions.co.uk/news/employers/2023/10/valuation-result.aspx for 2020.

Under the definitions set out in FRS 102, the TPS is an unfunded multi-employer pension scheme. The Academy has accounted for its contributions to the scheme as if it were a defined contribution scheme. The Academy has set out above the information available on the scheme.

LOCAL GOVERNMENT PENSION SCHEME

The LGPS is a funded defined benefit pension scheme, with the assets held in separate trustee-administered funds. The total contribution made for the year ended 31 August 2024 was £404,643 (2023 - £339,000), of which employer's contributions totalled £323,179 (2023 - £269,000) and employees' contributions totalled £ 81,465 (2023 - £70,000). The agreed contribution rates for future years are 21% & 17.60% per cent for employers and 5.50% - 12.50% per cent for employees.

Parliament has agreed, at the request of the Secretary of State for Education, to a guarantee that, in the event of academy closure, outstanding Local Government Pension Scheme liabilities would be met by the Department for Education. The guarantee came into force on 18 July 2013 and on 21 July 2022, the Department for Education reaffirmed its commitment to the guarantee, with a parliamentary minute published on GOV.UK.

24. PENSION COMMITMENTS (CONTINUED)

PRINCIPAL ACTUARIAL ASSUMPTIONS

Dorset

	2024	2023
	%	%
Rate of increase in salaries	**3.85**	3.90
Rate of increase for pensions in payment/inflation	**2.85**	2.90
Discount rate for scheme liabilities	**5.05**	5.30
Inflation assumption (CPI)	**2.85**	2.90

The current mortality assumptions include sufficient allowance for future improvements in mortality rates. The assumed life expectations on retirement age 65 are:

	2024	2023
	Years	Years
RETIRING TODAY		
Males	**21.8**	21.8
Females	**23.9**	23.9
RETIRING IN 20 YEARS		
Males	**23.1**	23.1
Females	**25.3**	25.3

Devon

	2024	2023
	%	%
Rate of increase in salaries	**3.80**	3.90
Rate of increase for pensions in payment/inflation	**2.80**	2.90
Discount rate for scheme liabilities	**5.10**	5.30
Inflation assumption (CPI)	**2.80**	2.90

The current mortality assumptions include sufficient allowance for future improvements in mortality rates. The assumed life expectations on retirement age 65 are:

	2024	2023
	Years	Years
RETIRING TODAY		
Males	**21.4**	21.4
Females	**22.7**	22.6
RETIRING IN 20 YEARS		
Males	**22.7**	22.7
Females	**24.1**	24.0

24. PENSION COMMITMENTS (CONTINUED)

SENSITIVITY ANALYSIS

Dorset

	2024 £000	2023 £000
Discount rate +0.1%	**(16)**	(13)
Discount rate -0.1%	**16**	13
Mortality assumption - 1 year increase	**24**	18
Mortality assumption - 1 year decrease	**(24)**	(18)
CPI rate +0.1%	**16**	13
CPI rate -0.1%	**15**	12

Devon

	2024 £000	2023 £000
Discount rate +0.1%	**(50)**	(42)
Discount rate -0.1%	**51**	43
Mortality assumption - 1 year increase	**60**	52
Mortality assumption - 1 year decrease	**(59)**	(51)
CPI rate +0.1%	**51**	43
CPI rate -0.1%	**(49)**	(42)

24. PENSION COMMITMENTS (CONTINUED)

SHARE OF SCHEME ASSETS

The Academy's share of the assets in the scheme was:

	At 31 August 2024 £	At 31 August 2023 £
Equities	**1,791,000**	1,371,000
Corporate bonds	**603,000**	452,000
Property	**236,000**	211,000
Cash and other liquid assets	**73,000**	34,000
Other	**1,000**	-
Infrastructure	**304,000**	217,000
Multi Asset Credit	**54,000**	41,000
Target Return Portfolio	**55,000**	115,000
Diversity Growth Fund	**50,000**	39,000
TOTAL MARKET VALUE OF ASSETS	**3,167,000**	2,480,000

The actual return on scheme assets was £322,000 (2023 - £61,000).

The amounts recognised in the Statement of Financial Activities are as follows:

	2024 £	2023 £
Current service cost	**(262,000)**	(324,000)
Interest income	**141,000**	104,000
Interest cost	**(149,000)**	(127,000)
TOTAL AMOUNT RECOGNISED IN THE STATEMENT OF FINANCIAL ACTIVITIES	**(270,000)**	(347,000)

Changes in the present value of the defined benefit obligations were as follows:

	2024 £	2023 £
AT 1 SEPTEMBER	**2,783,000**	3,000,000
Current service cost	**262,000**	324,000
Interest cost	**149,000**	127,000
Employee contributions	**82,000**	70,000
Actuarial losses/(gains)	**64,000**	(615,000)
Benefits paid net of transfers in	**(43,000)**	(123,000)
AT 31 AUGUST	**3,297,000**	2,783,000

24. PENSION COMMITMENTS (CONTINUED)

Changes in the fair value of the Academy's share of scheme assets were as follows:

	2024	2023
	£	£
AT 1 SEPTEMBER	**2,480,000**	2,345,000
Administration expenses	**(1,000)**	(1,000)
Interest income	**141,000**	105,000
Actuarial gains/(losses)	**178,000**	(185,000)
Employer contributions	**328,000**	269,000
Employee contributions	**82,000**	70,000
Benefits paid net of transfers in	**(43,000)**	(123,000)
AT 31 AUGUST	**3,165,000**	2,480,000

The Academy Trust has an unrecognised surplus of £3,000 in respect of its Devon defined benefit pension scheme as it does not expect to recover the plan surplus either through reduced contributions in the future or through refunds from the plan.

25. OPERATING LEASE COMMITMENTS

At 31 August 2024 the Academy had commitments to make future minimum lease payments under non-cancellable operating leases as follows:

	2024	2023
	£	£
Not later than 1 year	**7,747**	7,806
Later than 1 year and not later than 5 years	**15,152**	22,179
	22,899	29,985

26. MEMBERS' LIABILITY

Each member of the charitable company undertakes to contribute to the assets of the company in the event of it being wound up while he/she is a member, or within one year after he/she ceases to be a member, such amount as may be required, not exceeding £10 for the debts and liabilities contracted before he/she ceases to be a member.

27. RELATED PARTY TRANSACTIONS

Owing to the nature of the Academy and the composition of the Board of Trustees being drawn from local public and private sector organisations, transactions may take place with organisations in which the trustees have an interest. All transactions involving such organisations are conducted in accordance with the requirements of the Academy Trust Handbook, including notifying the ESFA of all transactions made on or after 1 April 2019 and obtaining their approval where required, and with the Academy's financial regulations and normal procurement procedures relating to connected and related party transactions.

There were no related party transactions in the year, other than certain trustees' remuneration and expenses already disclosed in note 12.

28. POST BALANCE SHEET EVENTS

The assets, liabilities and operations of the Trust transferred to The First Federation Trust on 1 September 2024.